

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



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**The Old Great North Road**

- High Street
- Hall Gate
- French Gate

**The Medieval Town**

- St Sepulchre Gate
- Baxter Gate
- Scot Lane

**The Later Town**

- Silver Street & Cleveland Street
- Wood Street & Waterdale
- Printing Office Street
- Priory Place
- Priory Walk

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.1 Definition Of Character Areas

A number of discernable character areas are evident within the High Street Conservation Area, centred around individual streets, each with its own very individual character.

The character area boundaries in a complex and layered urban environment are inevitably subjective in places, and based not just on architectural or historic characteristics, but on the dynamic experience of the area – how it is perceived when walking or driving through it, and when ‘boundaries of experience’ are crossed. This includes such sensations as awareness of enclosure or openness, and degrees of noise or activity, which provide edges to areas just as much as map-based boundaries, or changes of use. It is on this basis that the following character areas have been identified.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### High Street Character Area

The High Street is the main 'showpiece' of Doncaster town centre, the seat of wealth, prosperity and civic pride. Its most prestigious location, the High Street is actually a surprising mix of styles. It contains the largest concentration of listed buildings, the most prominent of which is the celebrated 1746-8 Grade I Mansion House, the elaborate classical styling, proportions and scale of which operate as an urban stage-set, becoming the model for all proceeding buildings wishing to exert their presence within the town.

This mantle is taken up by the late 19<sup>th</sup> / early 20<sup>th</sup> century bank buildings, many of which are also listed. Monumental in scale (buildings are of 3 storeys, although one storey is often double height, meaning the actual height is closer to 4) and constructed of stone, these employ various architectural motifs such as rustication, heavy plinths, pilasters spanning several floors and deep cornices to convey a sense of wealth and solidity.

Some fine examples of Georgian double-fronted houses also exist, indicating the High Street's former status as a prestigious residential address as well as a commercial centre. Generally 3 storeys high, these are somewhat smaller than the Mansion House and the banks, lacking the double height ground storey. Construction is either of brick or stucco with slated roofs. There are also some more modest 2 bay houses from the same period on High Street.

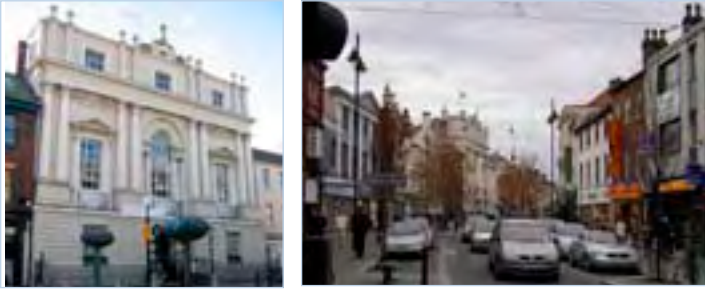
The 1908 Danum Hotel breaks the architectural order by introducing additional height in the form of dormers and profiled gables. Some modern buildings feature amongst the old, dating from both the immediate post-war period and later examples, the latter styled to match the original 18<sup>th</sup> and 19<sup>th</sup> century buildings. These conform to the original storey heights and building frontages. An anomaly is the oldest building within the town centre, dating from the 16th century (although much altered), giving a flavour of what the late-medieval character of the town centre would have been like.

The High Street has the overriding character of a business district (although some shops can be found, they are reasonably low-key). The width and space, when compared to the relatively narrow streets that lead into it, results in the crossing of an experiential boundary when entering it, from understated enclosure to expansive grandeur. This is also helped by its largely pedestrian character, emphasizing the scale of the buildings and the sense of space. As the main thoroughfare of the town it is busy throughout the week both during the day and into the night, the site of noise and activity but perhaps in a less frenetic, more refined way to some of the other main shopping areas and the Market Place.

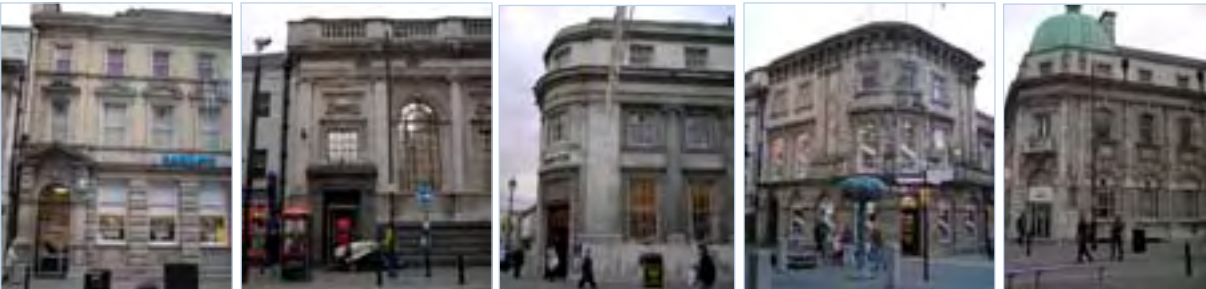


# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Mansion House occupies prime position within the High Street



Late 19th / early 20th century bank buildings within the High Street



Late 18th / 19th century former houses within the High Street



20th century buildings within the High Street



A 16th century survival on High Street

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Hall Gate Character Area

Hall Gate has significance and special interest within the context of the conservation area through its provenance as the old Great North Road and a large number of surviving 18th and 19th century buildings, many of which are listed.

The character of the area is overwhelmingly that of the Georgian town house. These range from large scale double-fronted examples to simple 2 bay or even 1 bay variants. Almost all are of 3 storeys and form a continuous building frontage to the rear edge of the pavement. Although some groups of 1 or 2 appear to have been built simultaneously, most have been built individually with the result that the buildings have subtly varied rooflines and a wide variety of individual details such as bays and balconies. There is, however, enough of a common language of details such as sash windows and stucco render to ensure homogeneity within the set of buildings.

Some shops exist, but Hall Gate could not really be described to be a retail area; its main functions are professional services such as estate agents and solicitors and the hospitality trade. In this respect Hall Gate could be said to be more leisure orientated, with a plethora of bars, public houses, clubs and restaurants, as well as a cinema. This switches much of its activity to night time, although it continues to be a busy thoroughfare throughout the day.

The continuous building frontage is punctured by a number of entrances and archways, hinting at spaces beyond the main street; these lead in some instances to yards and service areas behind the buildings, others give access to adjacent streets. One, Bradford Row, has been formalised into a glass covered arcade. On the southern side one such entrance leads through to the Free Christian Church, a substantial building that also fronts onto Wood Street behind.

The continuity of the building frontage is broken on the north side in two instances; the Hall Gate Methodist Church steps back from the pavement edge to create a courtyard to the front, which has been partially infilled by later structures. Further to the west an empty site created by the demolition of several buildings fragments the whole; this should be redeveloped as a matter of urgency.

Some late 19th / early 20th century buildings exist to the western end of the north range, introducing additional architectural features such as profiled gables into the mix that serve to animate the skyline and add variety. Unfortunately Hall Gate has suffered from several large unsympathetic modern interventions; on the south side Kingsway House and the buildings at the junction with the High Street, and nos. 20 to 22 on the north. Although these respect storey heights (and plot widths in the case of Kingsway House), the uncompromisingly modern and utilitarian character of the buildings does little for the integrity of the conservation area. This has been addressed at the entrance to Bradford Row by re-facing the building, but the result looks applied and could have been executed more convincingly.

Hall Gate has two issues that differentiate it from the main part of the town centre and High Street; traffic, and the often poor condition of buildings. It is a busy urban route, with a constant stream of buses and cars. Ironically, the apparent ease of access may be partly responsible for its visible decline, making it an undesirable environment to shop in. Which leads to economic decline, manifesting in disrepair.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Elaborate Georgian townhouses on Hall Gate. The Methodist Chapel (far right) breaks the otherwise continuous frontage



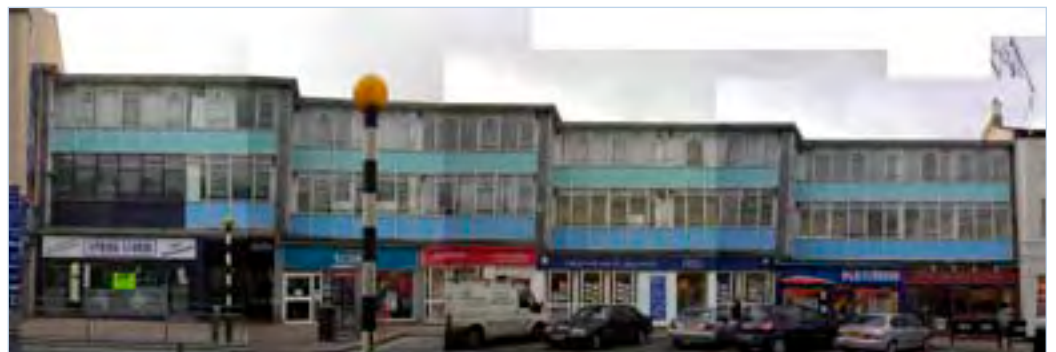
Gap site and vacancy on Hall Gate. Crossgate House (left) on Wood Street completely overpowers its surroundings



Alleyways and yards beyond the main facades; Bradford Row (far right) has been glazed over to create a shopping precinct



A late 19th / early 20th century addition on Hall Gate



Kingswood House; an unsympathetic post-war intervention on Hall Gate

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### French Gate Character Area

As the continuation of the old Great North Road and former site of a crossing over the River Cheswold, once part of the medieval town defences, French Gate has significance and special interest within the context of the town centre. However, this has been badly compromised during the 1960s and 1970s by the creation the Frenchgate Centre and Church Way, the latter truncating the route so that it no longer feels like a proper street, appearing more as a retail cul-de-sac.

The result of this is that the street does not really have an identity of its own any more, merely becoming a less prestigious continuation of the High Street or St Sepulchre Gate and a means to access the French Gate Centre or Marks and Spencer. Activity from the High Street peters out by the time one reaches the western end of the street, where the busy road effectively marks French Gate as the 'end' of the town centre.

As well as the loss of historic buildings to the complete southern side of the street, there are several modern interventions to the middle section of the northern side which replaced the 1848 Guildhall and several other historic structures. These respect the overall 3 storey building height and are innocuous enough, but their bland and characterless appearance in no way compensates for the loss of the previous structures. A small entrance between the buildings leads to Old Guildhall Yard, a dank, dark and uninviting alleyway that leads to further utilitarian modern buildings and Church Way.

There are, however, some survivals; the western end of the street has several 19th century townhouses of the standard type together with two 'Tudorbethan' public houses, one of which, the White Swan, still retains its original function. The eastern end of the street features further earlier townhouses, of which no. 12 is of high quality, and an interesting example of 1930s 'streamlined' architecture located in between. The corner is punctuated by the 1895 Clock Corner, built as a result of the widening of Baxter Gate, and which acts as a landmark within this part of town.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



View of French Gate facing east. Clock corner is in the distance, centre left, with the Frenchgate Centre to the right. Church Way cuts across in the foreground.



View facing north showing truncation by Church Way; the public house in the foreground was formerly in the middle of a terrace



Large department stores typify the streetscape along modern French Gate by Church Way



An example of 1930s 'streamlined' architecture



No. 12 French Gate; a rare historic survival with public art / street furniture outside



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### St Sepulchre Gate Character Area

Similar in terms of dimensions and massing to the High Street, although less prestigious, the significance and special interest of St Sepulchre Gate lies in its status as one of the original medieval routes through the town, connecting the town's defensive ditch with the High Street, as well as in the survival of some good quality early to mid 20<sup>th</sup> century buildings.

The main difference is the loss of the historic buildings to the western side of the street and its replacement with the modern French Gate shopping centre; this has the effect of altering the character from what might have been very similar to the High Street (3 / 4 storey stone-built commercial buildings) to that of a primary retail area. St Sepulchre Gate marks an experiential boundary, comprising the whole gamut of retail experience more comprehensively than anywhere else within the town centre. This ranges from market stalls at its most basic level, with their associated sights and sounds, through to independent shops contained within mixed use buildings with offices over, to purpose-built malls containing a huge variety of national retailers.

Consequently, the junction with High Street is particularly busy with the hustle and bustle of shoppers, activity that, similar to the High Street, maintains a constant presence throughout the week both during the day and into the night. To further facilitate the shopping environment, the street is pedestrianised.

Many historic buildings have been demolished to make way for modern development. There are, however, some interesting survivals to the eastern side, of which the former *Nags Head Hotel* is listed. Buildings here are almost entirely of stone, conforming to the 3 or 4 storey pattern found on the adjacent High Street, although stepping up to 5 in some instances on the north east corner. Indeed, some of the buildings here, such as the Co-operative bank or Royal Bank of Scotland, would not look out of place on the High Street.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Views south (left) and north along St Sepulchre Gate showing the relationship between market, shop, office and shopping centre



St Sepulchre Gate junction with High Street, French Gate and Baxter Gate



Grade II listed former Nags Hotel



Prestigious stone-built buildings on St Sepulchre Gate similar to those on High Street. The Royal Bank of Scotland is to the far left, The Co-operative Bank third from the right. This impressive array of buildings is the result of redevelopment following road widening schemes during the early / mid 20th century.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Baxter Gate and Scot Lane Character Area

Although these streets have their own individual character, they also share a great many similarities. Their significance and special interest lies in the fact that both are medieval thoroughfares connecting the High Street with the Market Place, and both are notable examples of early 20th century town improvements in the form of road widening to their western sides, carried out as a result of the 1904 Doncaster Corporation Act.

Baxter Gate is a primary retail area, benefiting from its proximity to French Gate and St Sepulchre Gate, acting as a continuation of the latter down into the Market Place. This enables it to attract a number of large national retailers, and as a consequence is the busier of the two, with a constant footfall throughout the week during retail hours, aided by its pedestrianised status. Scot Lane is a more down-at-heel neighbour, populated by independent retailers and still accessible by motor car. The absence of any licensed premises (except for one on Scot Lane) means that both are relatively quiet during the evenings.

In terms of buildings, both streets conform to the familiar town centre model of 2 to 4 storeys, with 3 being the most prevalent, faced with either brick or render. Some simple 18th and 19th century buildings of the simple town house variety survive to the eastern sides of both streets (two on Baxter Gate are listed) alongside more elaborate 19th / early 20th century examples that introduce architectural motifs such as profiled Dutch gables, canted bay windows and clock towers. Road widening during the early 20th century presented the Corporation with the opportunity to redevelop sections of streets in planned terraces of 6 or so units rather than on the hitherto individual basis. These were often examples of polite architecture that reflected the wider influences of the time.

Although there are examples on both streets, Baxter Gate in particular has more modern interventions and fewer surviving older buildings, with several large department stores located on its western side

The streets have a sense of enclosure in counterpoint to the wide spaces of the High Street, French Gate and St Sepulchre Gate, and despite the popularity of Baxter Gate they feel more as places to pass through between the Market Place and High Street rather than destinations in themselves.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Large department stores to the western side of Baxter Gate are indicative of busy retail activity



A variety of building styles and periods on Baxter Gate



Nos. 24 & 25 on Baxter Gate; listed Grade II



Scot Lane facing north with the Market Place in the distance; some 19th century buildings survive to the eastern side



Scot Lane facing south showing relationship with High Street, illustrating the contrasting narrowness of the street and smaller size of buildings

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Silver Street and Cleveland Street Character Area

These streets have their own individual character but share many similarities that warrants their inclusion together here. Their main significance and special interest is derived from their proximity to the medieval defensive town ditch, one running into the other, and that they are examples of early 20th century road widening schemes. Both were known by an assortment of names before gaining their current titles; Silver Street in 1793, Cleveland Street following in 1833. Shops can be found on both streets, but they are outside of the main retail areas. The pedestrianisation of much of the town centre means that Silver Street and Cleveland Street are the main routes for traffic to circumnavigate the town centre, and congestion is a problem. In this sense they feel very much as the boundary marking edge of the town centre, which may account for the shabby and neglected appearance of many of the buildings

Widening of Silver Street took place to the western side, the redevelopment of which largely took the form of Corporation built terraces of 6 or so units with commercial space to the ground floor and living accommodation over, forming a continuous building line to the rear edge of the pavement. Brick built, these are largely extant. As a result of the unstable ground conditions associated with the former town ditch most are 2 storeys high and are characterised by dormers and profiled gables. As examples of the few 'planned' developments of a series of plots (as opposed to individual developments) they are important in the context of the character of the town centre, signalling a new era of improvements. Taller buildings followed to the junction with Hall Gate, although these share common materials such as brick and terracotta that allow them to blend with the existing urban fabric. Unfortunately the same principles were not carried through to the redevelopment of the eastern side, and much of the historic character of the street has been lost. Silver House, a 1960s office development is particularly incongruous in terms of its size, massing and utilitarian style.

Silver Street's principal function is as the focus of Doncaster's night life, with public houses, restaurants, bars and several clubs, along with a number of fast-food establishments. For this reason the character of Silver Street changes dramatically according to the time of day and week. During the daytime many premises are closed, and it is relatively quiet with few pedestrians. However, at night (particularly during weekends), it becomes extremely busy.

Cleveland Street was widened at the junction with Hall Gate in the early 20th century with the building of the 4 storey Danum Hotel. The street contains a mix of 2 and 3 storey buildings of a similar period, interspersed with several more recent unsympathetic interventions, such as the Danum Hotel extension, which despite some good brickwork detailing to its principle facade is, at 6 storeys, out of scale with the surrounding buildings. The 1960s building to the junction with Hall Gate fits relatively well in terms of scale and massing, but its uncompromisingly modern style is at odds with the character of the area and its poor condition further contributes to its negative impact. The most recent addition to the street is a range of 2 storey brick buildings at the junction with Printing Office Street with stone detailing and a conical tower at one end that complement the scale, materials and style of their older counterparts.

The buildings along the street present a continuous frontage to the rear edge of the pavement, but the street appears more fragmented due to the presence of a number of intersecting roads and entrances to service yards. In one of these (accessed through the 1960s corner building) a stone wall can be found, a remnant of the Reindeer Hotel that previously occupied the site, demolished in 1962.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



5 and 4 storey buildings to the corner of Silver Street and Hall Gate



Silver House is out of scale with its surroundings



Corporation built 2 storey buildings to Silver Street, west side



Late 19th / early 20th century pub, east side



Modern 2 storey buildings to Cleveland Street (left) and older examples (right)



The Danum Hotel extension (left) overpowers its surroundings, including the original 1908 building (right)



Unsympathetic modern intervention at the Hall Gate / Cleveland Street junction



Surviving stone wall to rear yard, a remnant of the Reindeer Hotel



2 and 4 storey buildings, Cleveland Street east side



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Wood Street (& Waterdale) Character Area

Wood Street is significant as a reminder of the town's original edge between the urban and rural; not opened as a thoroughfare until 1789, the land to the south was occupied by a field known as Pell's Close. Special interest also lies in the surviving historic buildings and the pattern of development as a municipal area as well as a commercial and residential centre that can still be recognised today.

The street still retains something of this peripheral character, having a different essence to the remainder of the town centre which comprises mainly of former dwellings converted for commercial use and large corporate and civic structures. On Wood Street the continuous terraces gave way to a variety of individual structures that were more municipal and institution based, such as schools, chapels and churches and the (now demolished) Infirmary.

The pattern of development is sparser; buildings are still tight to the back of the pavement but are punctuated by gaps that lead to yards and open spaces to the rear. The street frontage is more permeable than elsewhere, giving a sense of space-behind-space layering and establishing a hierarchy between the public street and private subsidiary areas. Overall the experience is one of a sense of space and amenity not encountered elsewhere within the conservation area. The 1852 Ordnance Survey map (see page 27) shows much of the area occupied with the rear gardens of properties facing onto Hall Gate; even today it is not difficult to perceive how this would have worked and how the area might have appeared.

Buildings are generally 2 storeys high and of brick or render with slated or tiled roofs, although some modern interventions in the centre of the north side have raised the height to 3. Activity on the street focuses on the hospitality trade, with several bars (one of which is located in a former church) as well as more specialist retail outlets such as a motorcycle showroom. There are some interesting survivals towards the western end in the form of the original school and church buildings, which include some well considered, well crafted high quality buildings demonstrating care and attention to detail.

Sadly, the same cannot be said for the south side. At over 7 storeys high and occupying half of the frontage of the south side of Wood Street, the recent Crossgate House, built on the site of the former Infirmary is completely out of scale, not only with its immediate surroundings but also further afield, exerting an overpowering presence over a wide part of the town.

Only a small part of Waterdale is included within the conservation area; a small parade of 2 storey premises, an industrial unit and Consort House, a 6 storey office block. In common with Crossgate House, the latter is incongruous in terms of size, massing and style, particularly its dark brick cladding and horizontal strip windows.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



High quality individual buildings on Wood Street with yards to rear (right)



Development along Wood Street is sparser, with gaps between buildings and set backs from the road edge on the corner of Wood Street and Waterdale (right)



Crossgate House (left) and Consort House (right) are incongruous in terms of scale and style

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Priory Place Character Area

Priory Place is unique within the context of the High Street Conservation Area in that it is a planned street, created during the 1830s. As an early example of town planning with a number of surviving original buildings the street has significance and special interest

The character is very much one of architectural order; built as continuous terraces with common detailing such as sash windows, regularly sized and spaced openings and common materials such as stucco to the facades. Originally intended as dwellings, the ground floors were converted for retail use during the early 20<sup>th</sup> century. However, the street retains a domestic character, with fewer shops and more office based use, such as solicitors and other professional services. This creates a quiet enclave away from the hustle and bustle of the High Street.

The homogenous composition was fragmented during the mid 20<sup>th</sup> century by the demolition of part of the western terrace for the construction of the post office extension and the telephone exchange, both of which pull away and set back from the original street edge.

The Priory Methodist Chapel terminates the vista along the street, creating one of the few instances where a building has been purpose-built to fulfil this function. The difficulties of attempting to impose order within an existing urban environment becomes apparent when one considers that the chapel is built off-centre due to land acquisition problems, and that the terraces extend only to the centre section of the street due to the presence of existing properties at either end at the time of construction. Consequently, what initially appears to be ordered and complete has always been compromised to some degree.

The junction with the High Street was rebuilt to provide subsidiary buildings for the Mansion House, complementing the character of the existing buildings with two 3 storey properties and a 2 storey range, serving to terminate the composition. A new Post Office and bank building followed later on the other side, although these are closer to the character of the High Street in their civic appearance and commercial presence. The Printing Office Street junction features an early 20<sup>th</sup> century brick building with stone detailing to the western side, and to the eastern side the remains of a stable block, the central arch of which originally gave entry to Priory Place prior to the construction of the Chapel.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Priory Place facing south; the chapel was built off-centre due to land acquisition problems



Priory Place facing north showing the later post office and bank building



The original terrace to Priory Place in the centre section of the east side



1852 map; the western terrace has yet to be built



The east side of terrace to Priory Place showing the later ancillary buildings to the Mansion House and two storey section to the left

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Printing Office Street Character Area

Printing Office Street is significant through its location over the top of the medieval defensive ditch, together with the survival of a number of historic buildings, of which the Priory Methodist Church is listed. Also, due in part to its location on the edges of the town centre in an historically less densely populated area (the grounds of the Carmelite Friary once backed onto it) the street played a pivotal role in the development of light industrial activities within Doncaster; the Doncaster Gazette printing works from which the street derives its name were established here in 1812. There were also several builders premises and furniture repositories. The presence of the Priory Methodist Church also includes it as part of the mid 19th century urban composition of Priory Place.

Only the north side is included within the conservation area, although there are a number of buildings on the south side that reflect the pattern of development elsewhere on the street. The buildings are a lively mix of styles, scale and periods, ranging from short 2 storey late 19th / early 20th century terraces (built as a result of unstable ground conditions associated with the former ditch), to larger commercial buildings of a similar period. The earliest building is the remains of a former stable block, located on the eastern corner of Priory Place (see Priory Place Character Area).

There has been much recent modern intervention at the east end of the street, on the north side, although this is generally in character with its historic counterparts, with common scale, massing, detailing and materials.



Remains of the stable block on the corner with Priory Place



Priory Methodist Church



The former Temperance Hall converted to commercial use



Two and-a-half storey houses with commercial space on the ground floor in Printing Office Street



Recent commercial property to the corner of Priory Walk



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Priory Walk Character Area

This is a modern intervention utilising an older yard in the centre of the urban block and adapting it to create a new through-route between High Street and Printing Office Street, running parallel with Priory Place. It gives a much needed new use for the listed archway that once formed the entrance portico to The Subscription Betting Rooms, the remainder of the building having been demolished in 1974

The west side is made up of 2 and 3 storey 19th century simple brick properties with modern single storey extensions at ground floor level that can be accessed to act as roof terraces. The east side features new buildings in a complementary style, constructed of brick with stone dressings and a service yard to the rear accessed off of Cleveland Street.

Some shops exist, but the primary uses are in the hospitality trade, with a number of cafes, restaurants, bars and nightclubs. Patterns of occupation vary according to the time of day or week, although it is generally busiest in the evenings at weekends.

Passing through the entrance archways at either end one crosses an experiential boundary, from the hustle and bustle of Printing Office Street or High Street in particular to a quiet pedestrianised enclave with alfresco seating.



Priory Walk facing north towards High Street



Priory Walk facing south towards Printing Office Street



Former entrance portico of the Subscription Betting Rooms on High Street with Priory Walk beyond



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



- Wide Grain
- Medium Grain
- Close Grain
- Conservation Area Boundary

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.2 Activity and Prevailing or Former Uses and Their Influence on the Plan Form and Buildings

In terms of form & grain, the High Street Conservation Area can be split into three categories that relate to their current and historic uses:

- \* **Wide Grain:** Large buildings with substantial footprints typically found on High Street, St Sepulchre Gate, French Gate and parts of Baxter Gate. These tend to be more recent structures.
- \* **Medium Grain:** Intermediate sized buildings as found throughout the town centre, although concentrated around Hall Gate and parts of Wood Street and Cleveland Street. These comprise a mixture of historic and more recent structures.
- \* **Close Grain:** Smaller buildings comprising of mostly historic structures, found on Scot Lane, Priory Place, Silver Street, Printing Office Street and parts of Baxter Gate

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Wide Grain

Historic examples of these buildings are characterised by the large commercial buildings along High Street and St Sepulchre Gate. Most of these date from the late 19th and early 20th century. The geographical associations are important, the buildings are concentrated around the most prestigious part of town, establishing it as the financial and commercial hub of the town. Built, (and in most cases still occupied) by companies offering financial services such as banks and building societies, these were intended to convey a sense of stability, solidity and wealth. The commercial activities contained within them demanded large open spaces, resulting in large footprints and double height spaces.

These qualities are also expressed in the elevational treatment, which is similarly 'wide grain' with tall, giant elements such as pilasters and embellishments such as domes. Windows are large and widely spaced, set within stone walls modelled with large-scale ashlar blocks.

Mansion House is unique here in both its age and status as a civic structure. However, it shares many characteristics with the later bank buildings and could be described as a model for them. Originally built as accommodation for the Mayor and as a venue where he could entertain, it is intended to impress, featuring large formal rooms with lavish decoration. Such features are found within the bank buildings, and the elevational treatment of many of them follows the monumental classical order of the Mansion House.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



No. 1 (left) & no. 3 (right) High Street



Mansion House



Nos. 47 & 48 High Street



No. 55 High Street

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Medium Grain

Historic buildings of this type are generally found along Hall Gate and some surviving sections of High Street. The land abutting Hall Gate was originally laid out as medieval burgage plots, stretching back to Wood Street to the south and as far as East Laith Gate to the north. The extant historic buildings were built individually as houses for the fashionable wealthy citizens of the town during the 18th and 19th centuries, forming a continuous frontage along the old Great North Road. It is significant that these buildings are slightly removed from the town centre, where there was more space available away from the hustle and bustle. Buildings to the south side tend to be larger with wider frontages facing the road, and many of them conform to the dimensions of the original burgage plots, although the spaces to the rear have been curtailed. The 1852 Ordnance Survey map (see page 25) shows a number of elaborately planted gardens behind the frontage buildings, indicating that many were still in residential use at that time. Most were later converted to offices and shops, but the original house form still predominates.

As a result of this residential origin, the plan form is tighter and more dense than that of High Street. Although generous by modern standards, internal spaces are nonetheless domestic in scale, lending themselves to easy conversion. The individual nature of the houses means that layouts vary, but the standard arrangement of one room to the front with another to the rear and staircase to the side is prevalent amongst the more modest examples. Larger double-fronted properties have central staircases with rooms either side.

The closer grain of development extends to the elevational treatment; windows are smaller with a more closely spaced rhythm, and facades are of brick or render scribed with ashlar lines, this reduction of the building to smaller component parts producing a more human scale.

Buildings of a similar plan area also exist to Wood Street, although these are later and tend to be of 2 storeys. The larger size is due to their original use as institutions, such as churches, chapels and schools, requiring larger single spaces for congregations to gather, and for small-scale industrial use, such as coach & wagon businesses, bottlers and printers. The sense of space here is also emphasised by the gaps between buildings.

Some medium-sized properties also exist in various locations within the town centre; these were often built during the late 19th and early 20th centuries as a result of road-widening schemes, tending to have retail units at ground floor and office accommodation above. The mass of the building was generally broken down into constituent parts to regulate the scale of the facade within the streetscape.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Large Georgian Houses on Hall Gate



Medium sized properties on Wood Street, used variously as schools, chapels and industrial premises



Medium sized properties within the town centre on Printing Office Street (left) and Baxter Gate (right); note the division of the facades into sections to regulate the scale of the buildings within the streetscape.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Close Grain

These properties are concentrated more within the old historic centre of town within the confines of the medieval fortifications in the town centre where space was at a premium. In common with Hall Gate, the older examples were originally built as houses during the 18th and 19th centuries and later converted for commercial use, often retaining living accommodation to upper floors. However, compared to the grander double-fronted examples, these tend to be of the more modest type of buildings, generally 3 storeys high (although some 2 storey examples exist) with 1 room to the front and rear and the entrance and staircase to the side.

Supremely adaptable, the buildings can be found in virtually every part of the town centre and were converted to a multitude of uses; for example, nos. 24 and 25 Baxter Gate were built as a pair of houses in 1754<sup>1</sup>. The Doncaster Gazette directory of 1906 lists 24 as being occupied by Scales & Sons, Boot and shoe makers, no. 25 as the Maypole Dairy Co. No. 24 is now a building society, and no. 25 shoe shop. Similarly, nos. 17 and 18 High Street were built as houses<sup>2</sup>, the same directory lists no. 17 as Woodmansey & Son, watchmakers and jewellers, and no. 18 as John Fogg, Gilder and Picture Dealer. No. 18 is now an opticians, whilst interestingly 17 is still in use as a jeweller. Despite these innumerable conversions and alterations, the domestic character of the buildings is still palpable, particularly with regard to the ‘close grained’ elevational treatment constructed of small-scale bricks plain or stucco facades with smaller windows set within a closely spaced rhythm.

Alongside these earlier examples there are also a number of late 19th and early 20th century properties that occupy similar locations and play a similar role within the town centre, providing premises for small businesses. These may take the form of 3 storey buildings on principle routes, but are generally associated with the redevelopment by Doncaster Corporation carried out as part of the road widening schemes during the early 20th century. Where this took place on the so-called Bardike streets (following the line of the medieval defensive town ditch; Silver Street, Cleveland Street and Printing Office Street) buildings are typically of 2 storeys due to the made up ground to ditch resulting in poor ground conditions unable to carry the load of taller structures, the former land use having a direct effect on the structures that were later built on it.

These buildings also differ from the earlier examples in that they take the form of short rows of terraces rather than individual buildings, due presumably to the fact that the Corporation had larger parcels of land on which to build rather than individual plots. Rather than conversions, these buildings were purpose-built with commercial premises to the ground storey with living accommodation above. The overall size of the developments are generally broken down into their constituent parts, enabling individual units to exercise their own identity whilst retaining the close-grained character of the street.

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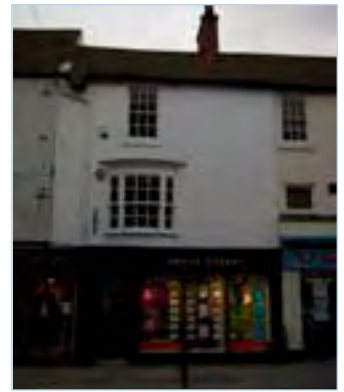
1 Listing description  
2 Listing description

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Close-grained properties on Priory Place, originally built as houses



Close-grained properties on Hall Gate (left) and Scot Lane (right)



Close-grained properties on Printing Office Street, built as commercial premises to the ground floor with living accommodation over

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.3 The Qualities of the Buildings and Their Contribution to the Area

The existing buildings within the Conservation Area date from the following periods;

- 16th century (one building, much altered)
- 18th century
- 19th century
- 20th century

The dominant architectural styles are as follows:

#### The Large Formal Georgian Townhouse

Found principally on Hall Gate and High Street, these buildings date from the late 18th or early 19th centuries, and are characterised by wide frontages of 3 to 5 bays, 3 storeys high. Built originally as houses for the more well-to-do inhabitants and the scene of many extravagant house-parties during race week, most have been converted to shops, offices or for the hospitality trade.

Elevations are of brick or more commonly render, with features such as rustication to ground floors, elaborate door and window surrounds and projecting string courses. Windows are generally of the small pane sash variety, full height to the first floor and decreasing in size to the upper floors; top storey windows are often square in the Palladian style. Bow windows and projecting or recessed elements with pediments or arched features can also be found, as can wrought or cast iron embellishments.

Roofs are generally pitched front to back with eaves front and rear. The front is often elaborated by a cornice; parapets are rare. The side gable that this creates generally features chimney stacks (although many pots are missing). Roofs are clad in either Westmorland or Welsh slates or clay pantiles.

A number of these type of buildings are listed Grade II (see section 4.4.7).



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Large double-fronted Georgian Houses on High Street (above) and Hall Gate (below), converted for commercial use



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### The Simple Georgian Townhouse

Also dating from the late 18<sup>th</sup> or early 19<sup>th</sup> centuries, these are far simpler than their more elaborate counterparts, characterised by narrower frontages of 2 bays, 3 storeys high. Built originally as houses, most have been converted to shops.

The most prevalent style of buildings to the High Street Conservation Area, the plot widths are fairly regular reflecting the original medieval burgage plots in some instances. The buildings were constructed on a piecemeal basis; there is little evidence to show that any more than 2 or 3 buildings were built at any one time, the dominant pattern being that of houses built to individual designs. The exceptions to this are Priory Place, built during the 1830s as terraces (a section of which are 2 storey), and Harwood terrace in Waterdale, built in 1826.

Facades are generally flat, constructed of brick or render. Door and window openings have simple stone cills, with windows generally of the small pane sash variety, full height to the first floor decreasing in size to the upper floors.

Although generally 3 storeys high, there is no uniform roofline. The unifying features are the materials, proportions and architectural features such as sash windows. When considered individually the buildings tend to have a vertical emphasis, but when viewed as a continuous unbroken length of façade the varying roof heights and rhythm and spacing of the windows means that the emphasis becomes one of horizontality. A number of these type of buildings are listed Grade II (see section 4.4.7).

A vernacular tradition appears to be the treatment of the roof. The buildings generally have relatively steep pitched roofs running front to back with the ridge line parallel to the front façade and eaves gutters, sometimes embellished. Roofs are clad in either slates or clay pantiles. The varying roof heights mean that in most cases the gables to the side elevations are visible, often the location of chimney stacks (many pots are missing). This allows the historical integrity of the structures to be read; in most instances it can be seen that the original enclosing walls of the buildings survives in its entirety, not simply the facades, conveying the depth and proportion of the original buildings.

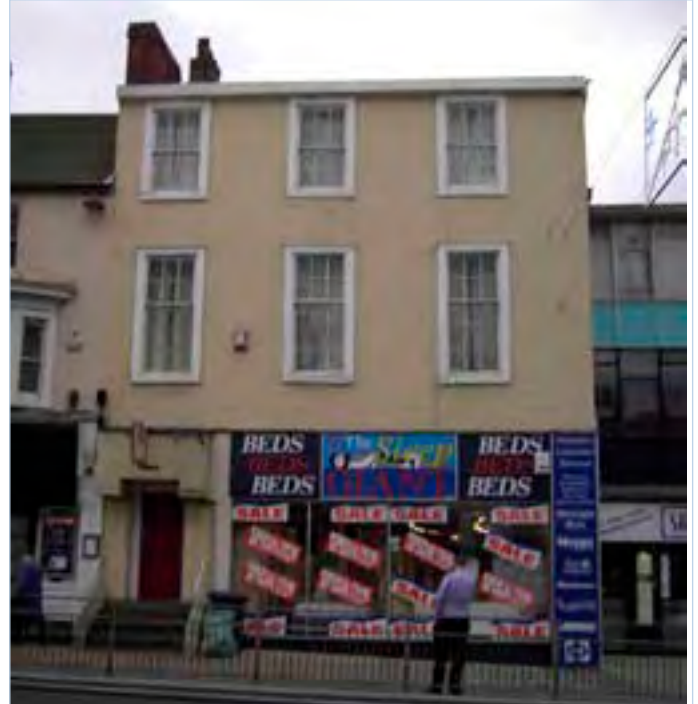
When viewed from alleys and yards, rear elevations offer an important insight into the original dense grain of development away from the formalised front façade, revealing a more random and haphazard approach to these unseen areas.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



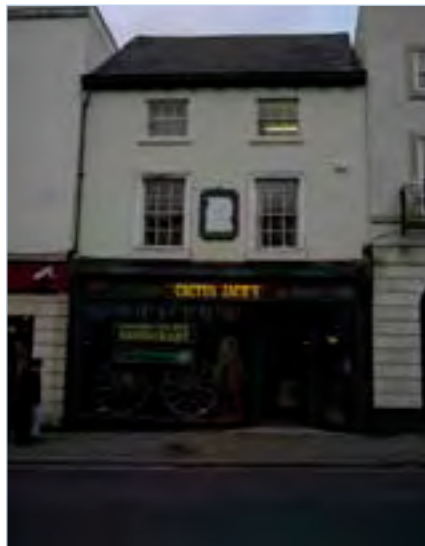
Priory Place



No. 45 Hall Gate



17 & 18 High Street



18 Hall Gate



Aspect to rear yard



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Large Civic / Financial Buildings

Dating from the late 19th and early 20th centuries, these buildings are found on the prestigious main thoroughfares of High Street and St Sepulchre Gate.

Constructed of stone of a variety of types ranging from Portland Stone to locally sourced sandstone laid in ashlar blocks with rustication to the ground storeys, the buildings typically comprise 3 storeys plus, in some instances, an attic storey. Ornament focuses on the use of giant classical orders; columns or pilasters stretching over several floors emphasise the monumentality of the buildings, supporting deep overhanging cornices.

Windows are typically sliding sashes set within heavy stone surrounds, full height to first floor reducing on upper storeys in the same manner as other older examples of classically-influenced buildings within the town centre. Entrances are large with elaborate surrounds, intended to impress and attract attention.

Roofs are generally concealed behind parapets, demonstrating wider architectural influences away from the vernacular tradition of overhanging eaves seen elsewhere within the town centre. Roof cladding is of Westmorland or Welsh slates.

Internal spaces typically comprise a large double-height banking hall with elaborate decoration to the ground floor with office accommodation to the upper storeys.

Most examples of this type of building are still used for their original purpose. A number are listed Grade II (see section 4.4.7).

The Mansion House is an example of this type of building, being the model for the later bank buildings, setting the tone in terms of scale, style and location.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



No. 27 St Sepulchre Gate



No. 55 High Street



No. 1 High Street



No. 19 St Sepulchre Gate

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### **Simple 2 / 3 Storey Houses and Commercial Properties**

Most of these date from the mid to late 19th century through to the early 20th century, and are of 2 storeys and 1 or 2 bays. They are found in various locations throughout the town centre, but typically characterise the streets around its edges such as Silver Street, Cleveland Street and Printing Office Street where they exist as a result of road widening schemes during the early 20th century.

These were often built by the Doncaster Corporation, and are characterised by small terraces as opposed to the Georgian townhouses that were built 1 or 2 at a time. Purpose-built, they have commercial premises on the ground floor featuring small scale shopfronts and residential accommodation over.

Materials are modest; brick or rendered facades with timber eaves. However, there are often embellishments such as decorated eaves cornices and string courses, stone cills & lintels, profiled parapets and decorated dormers that enliven the skyline and add interest to the streetscape. Interesting fenestration patterns also exist, including some bays. Large pane glass reflects the technology of the time.

Roofs are generally slate, pitched front-to-back in a similar fashion to other taller buildings in the area.

None of the buildings are listed, although most make a positive contribution to the townscape.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Two and-a-half storey houses on Printing Office Street



Two and-a-half storey houses on Silver Street



Two storey commercial properties on Cleveland Street



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 3 / 4 Storey Ornate Commercial buildings

These buildings generally date from the late 19th and early 20th centuries. Although found throughout the town centre, they are more common on primary routes such as High Street, St Sepulchre Gate, and Baxter Gate. Some such as Clock Corner on Baxter Gate and the Danum Hotel were built as a result of road widening schemes.

The buildings are unified into the whole through the continuation of storey heights and plot widths, the use of common materials such as red brick, stone and slate roofs, and architectural features such as sash windows. They are, however, more elaborate, introducing decorative elements of terracotta and faience, carved stonework and intricate ironwork into the overall palette. Windows are generally larger; arched lintels and heavy surrounds are common, as are timber or stone mullions to large pane sash windows. Much use is also made of 'feature' windows in the form of projecting bays or oriels in contrast to the flat facades of neighbouring structures.

The buildings often occupy prominent sites within the town centre, such as corners at major junctions, confirming them as important landmarks within the townscape. Corners are announced through the use of architectural devices such as clock towers, domes and cupolas, and the otherwise flat roofline of the town centre is animated through the use of dormers, balustrading, ironwork and multiple pointed and curved profiled gables.

The buildings are pivotal within the overall building stock in the town centre, heralding the arrival of a new 'improving' age, adding interest and variety through the introduction of wider architectural influences. Clock Corner on Baxter Gate and the Post Office on Priory Place are listed Grade II.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



No. 47 St Sepulchre Gate



No. 1 Baxter Gate



Priory Place Post Office



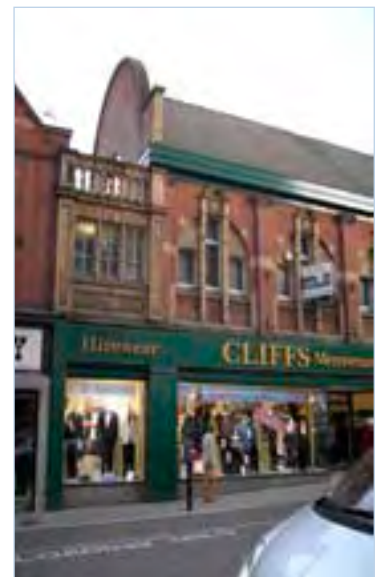
Danum Hotel, High Street



No. 4 Hall gate



No. 11 Printing Office Street



No. 13 & 15 Printing Office Street



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Twentieth Century Buildings

In addition to the large bank buildings around the High Street and St Sepulchre Gate there are a number of twentieth century buildings of several different styles and periods that make a varied contribution to the townscape.

Some from the earlier part of the century that pick up on and continue the language of the 3 or 4 storey ornate commercial buildings mentioned previously, albeit in a 'stripped-down' form. Decoration is not as elaborate, but the size, massing style and materials of the buildings are similar, and features such as projecting bays and oriel windows are common to both. None of these are listed but most make a positive contribution to the area.

The 'streamlined' international style of the 1920s and 1930s is represented by several buildings within the conservation area, introducing features such as strip windows and stripped down ornamentation. Of these, the former Nags Head Hotel and Danum House on St Sepulchre Gate are listed. The latter is currently outside the conservation area<sup>1</sup>, but its proximity to it is important, and the buildings clearly exerts great influence over this particular period of the town's architectural history.

Post-war interventions within the town centre are of variable quality; some such as those on St Sepulchre Gate and French Gate fit into the townscape innocuously enough, although none could be said to make a particularly positive contribution. Others, such as those on Hall Gate, Wood Street, Scot Lane, Priory Place and Waterdale are examples of utilitarian buildings with little architectural ambition or relationship with the adjacent historic buildings. This, together with their generally poor maintenance and shabby appearance results in their negative contribution.

Other later 20th century buildings have been built or re-modelled to match the style of the existing buildings, principally that of the Georgian townhouses. Whilst saying little about the age in which they were built, these nonetheless fit innocuously enough into the townscape. The recent redevelopment of the buildings to the north side of the High Street is a good example of how this approach can be achieved to good effect, stopping short of pastiche but utilising a common language of proportion, materials and details that enables the building to fit harmoniously with its surroundings. Other examples, such as that on the corner of Baxter Gate and St George's Gate are less successful, failing to pick up on the common language of architectural elements within the town centre and introducing incongruous elements such as deep overhanging eaves and expanses of brickwork with few openings.

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1 Although there are proposals to include it within the St Sepulchre Gate extension, see section 6.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Early 20th century buildings of a 'stripped down' decorated style; (left to right) Nos. 3 & 4 Baxter Gate, no. 1 Silver Street, no. 1 Hall Gate, no. 17 St Sepulchre Gate



20th century buildings of a 'streamlined' style; (left to right) no. 33 St Sepulchre Gate, Danum House, no. 10 French Gate, Danum Hotel extension,



Post-war modern buildings; (left to right) Marks & Spencer French Gate, Kingsway House Hall Gate, building to corner of Hall Gate and Cleveland Street



Late 20th century buildings; (left to right) Nos 15 & 16 Baxter Gate, nos. 7 to 10 High Street

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.4 Local Details

The historic core of Doncaster contains a rich variety of architectural details that contribute towards the distinctive local character. Such details should be preserved or their re-introduction considered when repairing or remodelling buildings within the town centre.

#### *Rounded Corners*

The first documentary evidence of the tradition of rounded corners in Doncaster can be traced back to 1789 when the Corporation purchased Miss Francis Wade's house at the corner of Scot Lane and the Magdalene's. William Lindley, the architect of the original Town Hall and theatre in Market Place, designed a house on the site with a rounded corner, possibly the first in Doncaster. For the next 150 years the Corporation pursued a policy wherever possible of rounding street corners, which it considered to be more elegant than square or chamfered examples, giving Doncaster a distinctive character. A number of rounded corners can still be seen within the High Street Conservation Area.

#### *Plinths*

Stone plinths, originally intended to protect the walls above from rising damp, are a feature of many historic buildings within the town centre. These are often painted, such as those on no. 39 Hall Gate. A particularly unusual example is the one on no. 26 Hall Gate, made up of individual limestone blocks.

#### *Roofs*

A distinctive feature of roofs within the town centre is the use of relatively steep pitched roofs running front to back with the ridge line parallel to the front façade and eaves gutters. This is in contrast to other contemporaneous roof profiles found elsewhere, which generally have shallower pitches behind parapet upstands.

#### *Bow Windows*

These are widespread throughout the High Street Conservation Area.

#### *Decorative Ironwork*

Many good examples of decorative ironwork can be found within the Town Centre.

#### *Decorative Stonework*

Many buildings within the town centre feature stonework in one form or another, usually sourced locally, indicative of the town's close proximity to a number of quarries and the ease of supply routes via the canal network. Most common are stone cills and string courses; other more prestigious buildings feature decorative stone details such as cornices, keystones and window surrounds and hoods.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

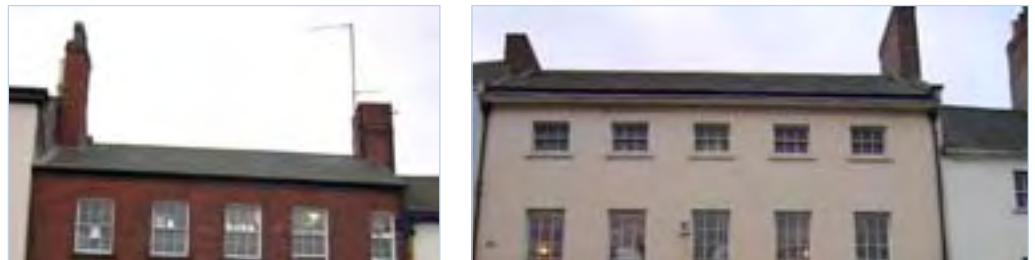
Rounded corners



Plinths



Roofs



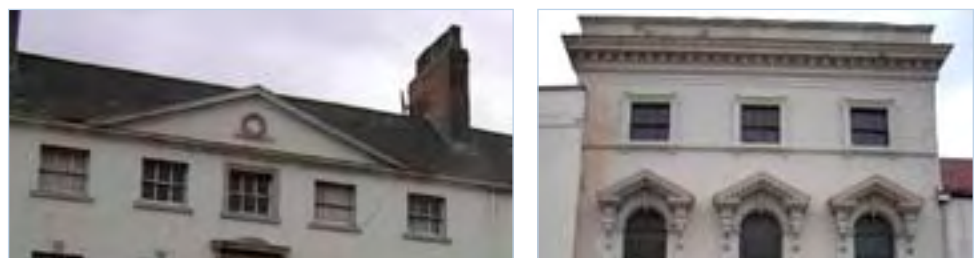
Bow windows



Decorative ironwork



Decorative stonework



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.5 Prevalent Local and Traditional Building Materials and the Public Realm

Prevalent and traditional materials found within the area are as follows:

#### **Buildings**

##### *Walls*

These are generally of brick, stucco or stone. Bricks colours range from a deep brownish red through to an orangey brown. No patterns from the use of burnt headers are evident, and no yellow or pale stocks are to be found. Bricks are generally laid in Flemish bond on front facades, with the use of English bond being prevalent for the construction of more utilitarian structures within rear yards. Some brick elevations have been painted, a practice that should be discouraged.

Stucco is generally smooth, although faint traces of ashlar blocks can be found scored into the surface of some properties such as 19 Priory Place. Stucco is generally painted white or light pastel colours.

Stone is used extensively for plinths and cills, and for decorative elements such as window surrounds. The most common type is a light brown medium / coarse-grained sandstone, widely available from a number of quarries within the wider area.

A number of prestigious buildings, principally banks, are constructed of stone; the material conveying an impression of wealth and solidity. Stone is obtained from a number of sources, some local, others from further afield, such as Portland Stone.

##### *Roofs:*

Surviving historic roofs are generally of slate; blue-green Westmorland slate, sometimes laid in graduated courses (the smallest at the top), or blue-purple Welsh slates, widely available from early in the 19th century. There are also some red clay pantiles examples, which were made at Sandall brickyards from the beginning of the 18th century. There has been some replacement of roofs within the area with modern materials such as concrete pantiles and reconstituted slate, but the majority of properties still retain the historic surfaces.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Stone facade, Scot Lane



Stucco facade, Priory Place



Brick facade, High Street



Welsh slate roof, High Street



Pan-tiled roof, High Street



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Walls & Other Freestanding Structures

There are relatively few freestanding walls within the conservation area; most are located within rear yards and are the remains of demolished buildings retained as boundary walls. Accordingly, these are generally built of brick of the same type as the buildings, in a mixture of Flemish and English bonds, sometimes both within the same structures. There are, however, some examples of stone walling within these areas, or stone being incorporated into areas of brick. These are probably remnants of demolished buildings, most notably the section located within the yard to the rear of the buildings on the corner of Cleveland Street and Hall Gate, which is possibly a part of the Reindeer Hotel, demolished in 1962.



Rear yards, Hall Gate, showing surviving stone structures

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Surfaces and Street Furniture

Surfaces within the High Street are predominately modern. These often take the form of concrete pavements in a variety of colours and designs which distract from the historic buildings and compromise their setting (see section 4.4.10). More successful are the areas of natural stone utilised for pavement surfaces within the town centre; York stone flags to pavement with granite setts and kerbs.

An area of historic surfacing in the form of pinkish-brown coloured smooth granite cobbles remains to the yard of the Free Christian Church on Hall Gate, although some areas may have been re-laid. Surfaces within rear yards and their approaches have generally been covered with tarmac; it is likely that this has been laid directly over the top of existing cobbles, presenting the opportunity to expose some areas of historic surfaces relatively easily.

An element of historic street furniture remains in the form of the Grade II listed cast iron lamp post in front of the Hall Gate Methodist Church. This could serve as a model for replacements within the conservation area.



Listed lamp post, Hall Gate Methodist Church



Rear yard, Free Christian Church, Hall Gate



York stone flags with granite setts and kerbstones



York stone flags with 'time-line' feature, High Street

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.6 The Contribution Made to the Character of the Area by Green Spaces and its Biodiversity Value

There are no green spaces within the High Street Conservation Area itself. The closest green spaces are St George's Churchyard to the west and Regents Square and the playing fields to the east:

- St George's Church graveyard is a haven of green space, but is severely compromised by the busy roads that surround it. Mature trees help to screening the church from the visual impact of the surrounding roads, but the overall impact is one of detachment from the rest of the town centre. The majority of the gravestones have been laid flat on the ground rather than vertically, which improves the impression of space and its utility, but alters the character of the graveyard somewhat. The relationship between the High Street Conservation Area and St George's churchyard should be improved.
- Located just outside the conservation area to the east, Regents Square is council owned and offers a green refuge away from the busy South Parade with mature trees and shrubs to its perimeter and grassed open space to the centre. An interesting link exists between Regents Square and the Market Place; a truncated column from St Mary Magdalene's Church uncovered during the 1846 demolition has been placed on the south side of the square, surmounted by the remains of the seated lion carrying a banner with a castle on it that once adorned the pediment of the theatre. Some form of plaque should be erected to make this connection explicit. The relationship of the square with the adjacent busy road could also be improved; the planting along this edge is rather sparse and could be thickened to create more of a barrier
- A possibility for a public space exists to the area in front of the telephone exchange on Priory Place. This is currently occupied by an under-used car park, but the space has the potential to return some much needed greenery back into the town centre; it is already occupied by some vegetation in the form of a large cotoneaster specimen towards the rear edge of the pavement. This line of planting could be extended to adjoin the original terraces, thereby serving to infill the gap created by the setting back of the telephone exchange and restore the original line of the street frontage.

There is also some historical precedent for this; the 1852 Ordnance Survey map shows a space with planting in approximately this location.

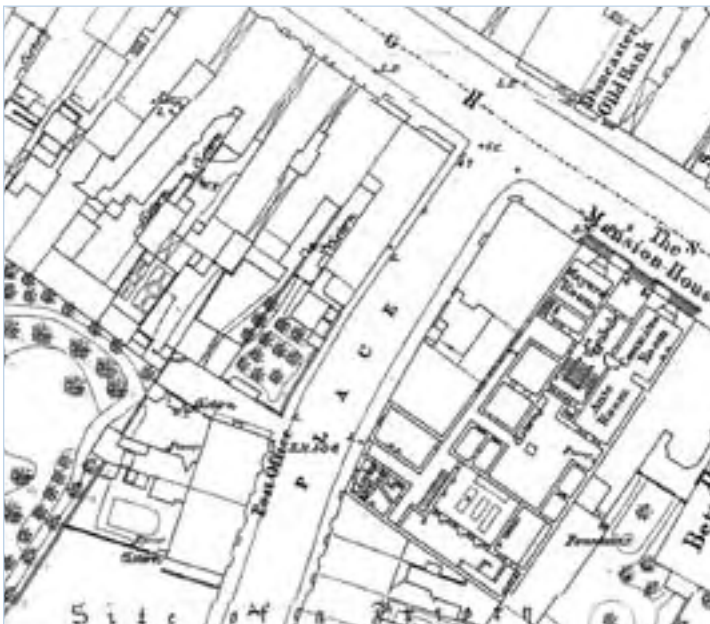


# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



St George's churchyard facing east



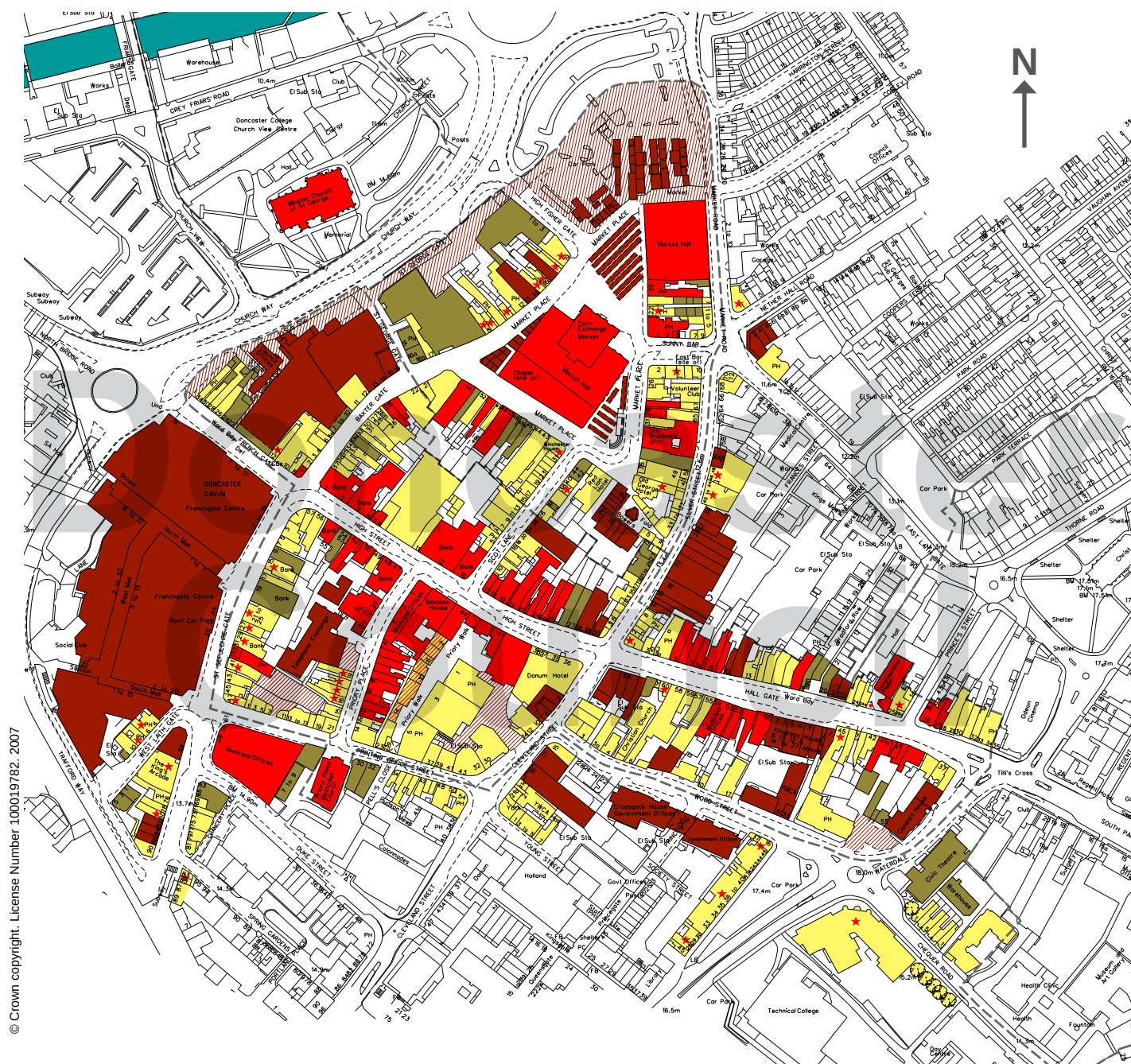
1852 map showing green space to west side of Priory Place



Lion from theatre pediment and column from St Mary Magdalene, currently in Regent Square

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



- Listed Buildings
- Positive Buildings
- Neutral Buildings
- Negative Buildings
- Negative Space
- Buildings Within Curtilage of Listed Building
- Conservation Area Boundary
- Key Unlisted Buildings



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.7 Listed Buildings

There are currently 46 entries on the Forty Second List of Buildings of Special Architectural or Historic Interest that are located within the High Street Conservation Area:

|    | Address                                              | Date of construction                | Listing Grade |
|----|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------|
| 1  | 1 Baxter Gate (west side)                            | 1892                                | Grade II      |
| 2  | 24 & 25 Baxter Gate (east side)                      | 1754                                | Grade II      |
| 3  | 5 Hall Gate (north side)                             | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 4  | 6 Hall Gate (north side)                             | mid 19th century                    | Grade II      |
| 5  | 7 & 7a Hall Gate (north side)                        | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 6  | 8 Hall Gate (north side)                             | late 18th century                   | Grade II      |
| 7  | 9 Hall Gate (north side)                             | late 18th century                   | Grade II      |
| 8  | 18 Hall Gate (north side)                            | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 9  | Lamp standard to front of Hall Gate Methodist Church | mid 19th century                    | Grade II      |
| 10 | Hall Gate Methodist Church                           | 1804, enlarged 1874                 | Grade II      |
| 11 | 26 Hall Gate (north side)                            | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 12 | 27 Hall Gate (north side)                            | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 13 | 39 Hall Gate (south side)                            | mid 18th century                    | Grade II      |
| 14 | 40, 41 & 41a Hall Gate (south side)                  | late 18th century                   | Grade II      |
| 15 | 50 Hall Gate (south side)                            | late 18th / early 19th century      | Grade II      |
| 16 | 51 Hall Gate (south side)                            | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 17 | 52 Hall Gate (south side)                            | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 18 | 53 & 54 Hall Gate (south side)                       | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 19 | 1 High Street (north side)                           | 1897                                | Grade II      |
| 20 | 3 High Street (north side)                           | 1882                                | Grade II      |
| 21 | 4, 5 & 6 High Street                                 | 16th century                        | Grade II      |
| 22 | 12 High Street (north side)                          | 1925                                | Grade II      |
| 23 | 16 High Street (north side))                         | 1841 / 1906                         | Grade II      |
| 24 | 17 High Street (north side)                          | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 25 | 18 High Street (north side)                          | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 26 | 19 & 20 High Street (north side)                     | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 27 | 21 High Street (north side)                          | 1841                                | Grade II      |
| 28 | 22 High Street (north side)                          | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 29 | 23 High Street (north side)                          | late 18th / early 19th century      | Grade II      |
| 30 | 24 & 24b High Street (north side)                    | late 18th century                   | Grade II      |
| 31 | 25 High Street (north side)                          | late 18th / early 19th century      | Grade II      |
| 32 | 40 High Street (south side)                          | 1780; re-faced c. 1920              | Grade II      |
| 33 | 41 High Street (south side)                          | late 18th century                   | Grade II      |
| 34 | 42 High Street (south side)                          | early 19th century                  | Grade II      |
| 35 | 43 High Street (south side)                          | 1826 (portico only)                 | Grade II      |
| 36 | 44 High Street (south side)                          | mid 18th / 19th century alterations | Grade II      |
| 37 | Mansion House                                        | 1746–50; 1801–06                    | Grade I       |
| 38 | 47 & 48 High Street (south side)                     | c. 1920                             | Grade II      |
| 39 | 50 & 51 High Street (south side)                     | mid 18th / 19th century alterations | Grade II      |



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

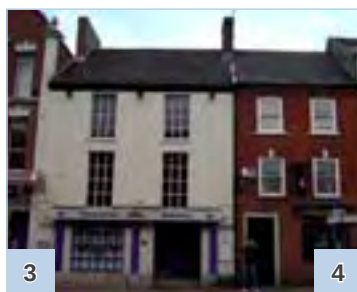
|    | Address                                           | Date of construction           | Listing Grade |
|----|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------|
| 40 | 52 High Street (south side)                       | early 19th century             | Grade II      |
| 41 | 55 High Street (south side)                       | 1912                           | Grade II      |
| 42 | Priory Methodist Church, Printing Office Street   | 1832                           | Grade II      |
| 43 | 1,2 & 3 Priory Place (east side)                  | late 18th / early 19th century | Grade II      |
| 44 | 4 to 13 Priory Place (east side)                  | early 19th century             | Grade II      |
| 45 | Post Office, 24, 25 & 26 Priory Place (west side) | c. 1885                        | Grade II      |
| 46 | Nags Head & 33 St Sepulchre Gate                  | c. 1930                        | Grade II      |



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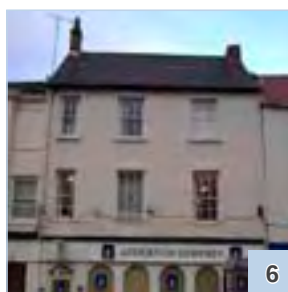


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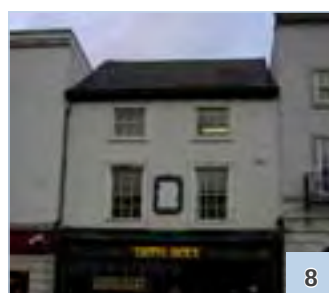
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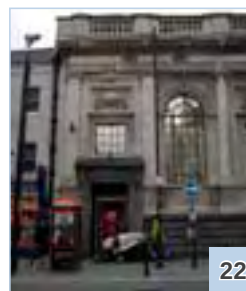
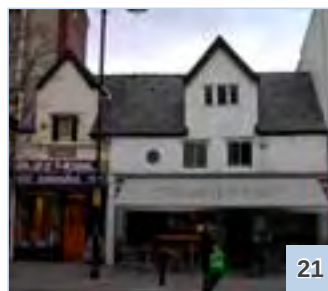
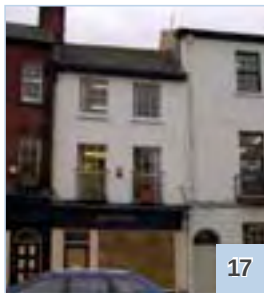
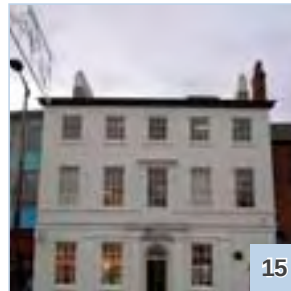
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# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

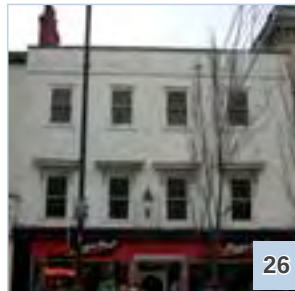


# Assessing Special Interest

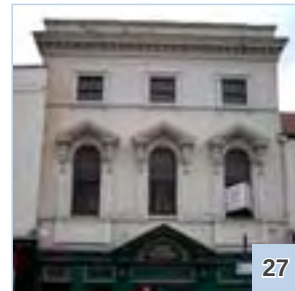
## 4.4 Character Analysis



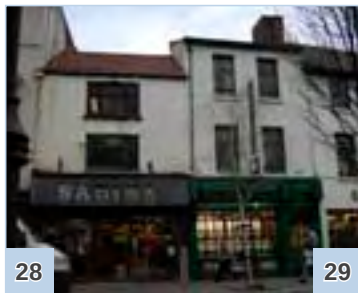
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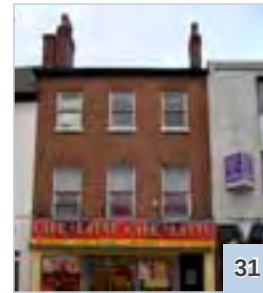
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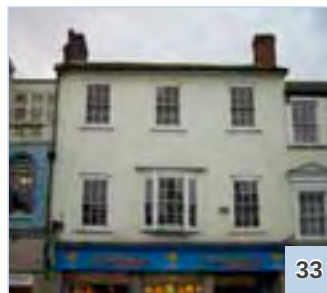
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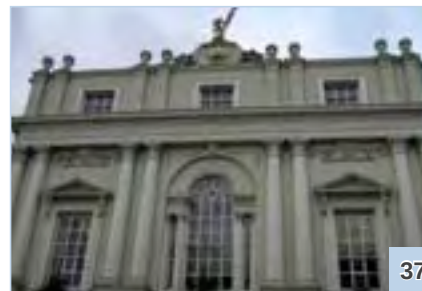
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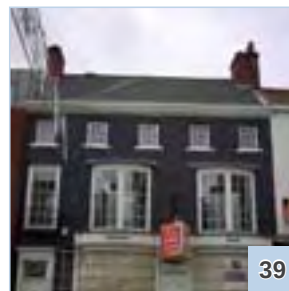
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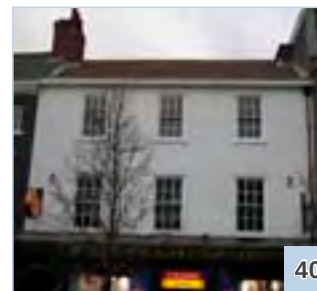
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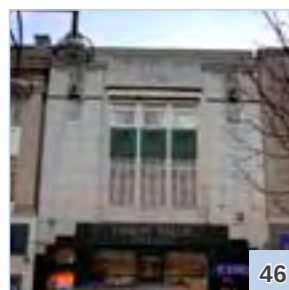
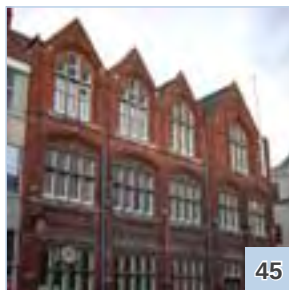
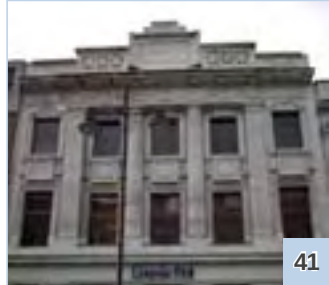


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# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.8 Unlisted Buildings

In addition to the listed buildings identified in the High Street Conservation Area, there are a number of unlisted buildings that make an important contribution to the character of the conservation area. These are identified on the map on page 100.

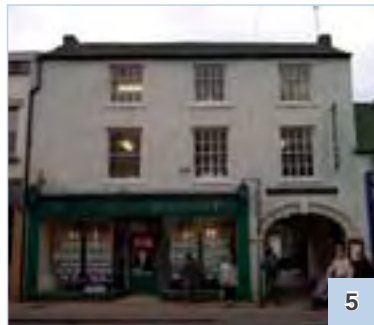
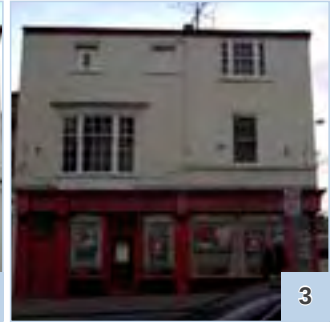
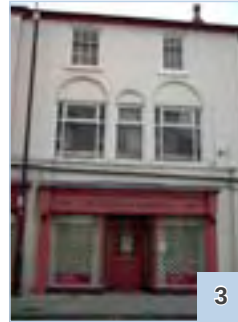
Although principally buildings of eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries, the buildings identified are by no means confined to these periods; buildings of any era can make a valuable contribution to the townscape provided they satisfy certain criteria in terms of scale, massing and attention to detail and fit well with the area contextually; indeed the variety of styles within a particular area is often responsible for a richness and vitality in terms of character and visual interest

### Key Unlisted Buildings

1. 12 French Gate: A good example of a surviving simple Georgian townhouse.
2. Prudential Chambers, 1 Hall Gate: A brick and stone building of 1912 displaying wider architectural influences, designed by Paul Waterhouse. Replacement of the modern shopfront would further enhance the appearance of the building.
3. 25 Hall Gate: An interesting Georgian townhouse of the more elaborate type, featuring a fine bow window and indented arches. The building frames the entrance to Prince's Street in conjunction with the listed example to the other side.
4. 45 Hall Gate: A double-fronted Georgian townhouse. Enhancement of the shopfront and entrance portico would improve the appearance of the building.
5. 60 Hall Gate: Of particular interest is the arched entrance to the Free Christian Chapel behind.
6. 16, 17, 18 and 19 Priory Place; mid 19th century buildings, slightly later than the listed east side. Some original features survive and the properties have been the subject of recent well informed restorations. The buildings fit well with the character of the other listed buildings on the other side of street, and the whole set has group value, although this is marred by the inappropriate modern shopfront and replacement windows of no. 16. Replacement of these would greatly enhance the individual building, as well as the terrace and streetscape in general.
7. 21 to 25, 27, 29, 31, 33, 41 St Sepulchre Gate; (including Nags Head, listed Grade II): Fine examples of early / mid 20th century buildings in an unbroken row they have group value, typifying an important and distinct stage in Doncaster's architectural heritage.
8. 47 St Sepulchre Gate: Erected by the Public Benefit Boot & Shoe Company in 1898, the building is a fine example of an elaborate late Victorian building and an impressive local landmark. The architects were Gelder and Kitchen of Hull.
9. Royal Bank of Scotland, St Sepulchre Gate; late nineteenth / early 20th century imposing Portland stone building, rusticated base, colonnaded upper floors, well proportioned, fits well with character of other listed bank buildings within High Street Area, adding to their group value.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis





# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.9 The Existence of any Neutral Areas

There are a number of buildings, mostly dating from the late twentieth century that can be viewed as having a neutral impact on the conservation area. These neither enhance nor detract from it, but lack the necessary stylistic attributes or presence to make a positive contribution.

Other buildings have been classified as neutral as a result of unsympathetic alterations or additions. Where appropriate, suggestions have been made to allow such buildings with sufficient potential to make more of a positive contribution

1. 33a Baxter Gate; late 20th century. The style is counter to the historic buildings along the street. However, the small scale and flat frontage results in a low impact on the streetscape.
2. Marks & Spencer, Baxter Gate & French Gate; 1960s (facades only, remainder of building facing Church Way has a negative impact): The use of natural stone and the scale and massing of the buildings fit the streetscape, with the French Gate facade broken down into smaller panels. However, the buildings lack the necessary styling to make a positive contribution to the character of the conservation area
3. 22 to 24 French Gate; 1960s: The size and proportions of the openings match those on historic town houses. Re-fenestration and more sympathetic signage would enable a more positive contribution to the conservation area.
4. 19 / 20 Hall Gate; 1960s, with later additions: Whilst unconvincing, the later facade is an improvement on its previous appearance which can still be seen next door at 21 / 22 Hall Gate.
5. 61 Hall Gate; 1800s: Re-fenestration and use of more sympathetic signage would allow this historic building to make a positive contribution to the conservation area. Re-roofing with natural red clay pantiles and removal of external roller shutters are also recommended.
6. 26 & 27 High Street; 1960s: The building fits the streetscape in terms of scale and massing and the use of natural stone, but is stylistically at odds with more historic examples. More sympathetic shopfronts would facilitate a more positive contribution to the conservation area.
7. 53 & 54 High Street; 1970s: The buildings lack the necessary styling to make a positive contribution to the character of the conservation area, but nonetheless work contextually in terms of materials and massing.
8. 20 to 27 Silver Street; 1960s: The size and proportions of the openings are at odds with those on the historic adjacent, although the buildings fit innocuously enough into the streetscape in terms of height, massing and the continuation of the horizontal emphasis of the facades. More sympathetic signage would improve the contribution made to the conservation area.
9. Modern bank buildings St Sepulchre Gate; 1970s: The scale, massing, stone facing and rhythm and size of openings matches the older examples in the street, but the bland repetitive aesthetic precludes a positive contribution.

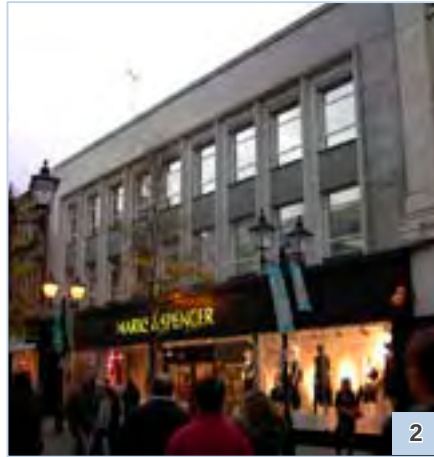
# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

10. Buildings to east of Waterdale (adjacent to Consort House): The small scale and location away from the road ensures that these buildings (which appear to be unsympathetically altered 19th century examples) are innocuous enough. Re-fenestration and more sympathetic signage would allow them to make a more positive contribution to the conservation area.



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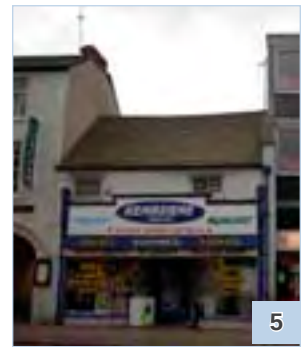
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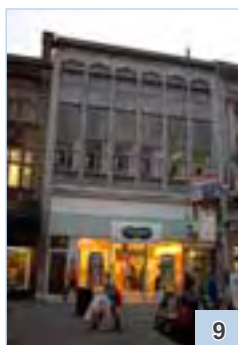
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# Assessing Special Interest

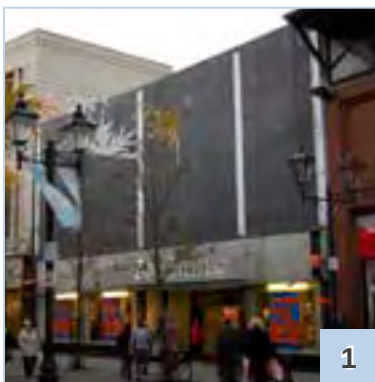
## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Buildings:

Although they make up a small percentage of the overall buildings within the High Street Conservation Area, there are several structures that detract from it and could be suitably be replaced or remodelled.

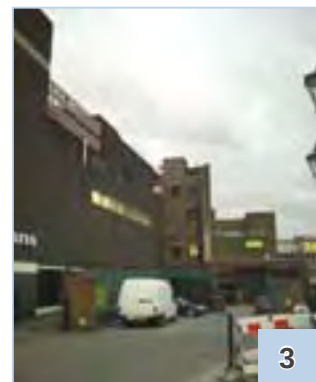
1. 13 & 14 Baxter Gate (Binns extension): The monolithic nature of the facade is at odds with the tighter-grained character of the historic buildings that front onto the street.
2. 15 to 16 Baxter Gate; 1990s: Fails to exploit its location on a corner site and address St George's Gate. Introduces incongruous stylistic elements such as deep overhanging eaves.
3. Marks & Spencer / Binns (rear elevations facing Church Way): Monolithic structures that fail to address the adjacent highway
4. Danum Hotel extension, Cleveland Street: Although the building has interesting details typical of its era and terminates the vista along Wood Street, aspects from other locations are less successful, particularly that from Cleveland Street facing north. The height, massing and use of materials should not be taken as a precedent for future redevelopment within the town centre.
5. Frenchgate Centre, French Gate / St Sepulchre Gate: Some major works have recently occurred that have introduced features characteristic of the town centre such as rounded corners, together with other architectural devices in an attempt to break up the whole. However, despite being outside the conservation area the building still has considerable impact due to its scale, use of materials and colours and should therefore be considered as negative.
6. 10 to 12 Hall Gate: A vacant site conveying a sense of dereliction and abandonment.
7. 21 & 22 Hall Gate: Stylistically at odds with the historic context.
8. Kingsway House, Hall Gate; 1960s: Stylistically at odds with the historic context and in a poor state of repair.
9. Corner Hall Gate / Cleveland Street, 1960s: Stylistically at odds with the historic context and in a poor state of repair. A sensitive refurbishment could improve the overall appearance.



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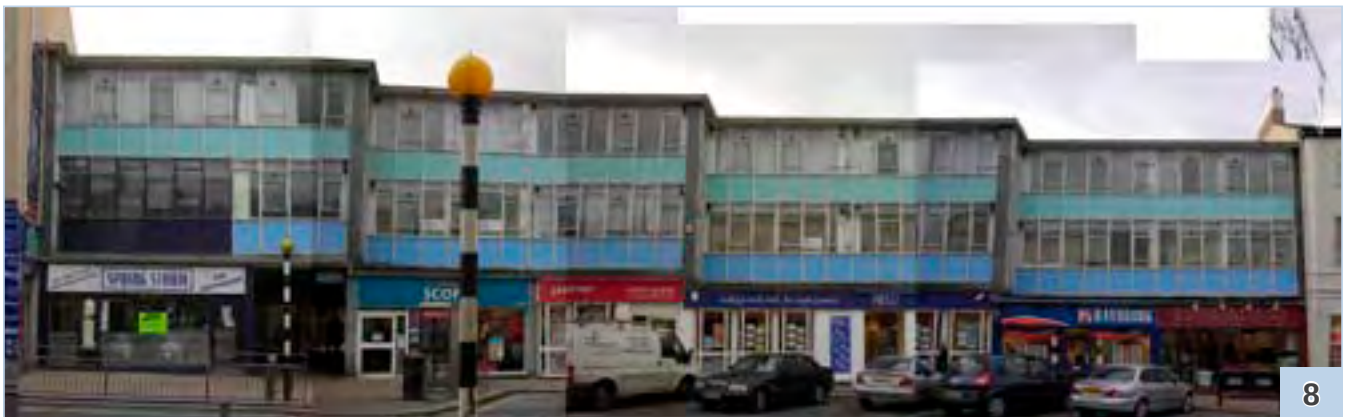
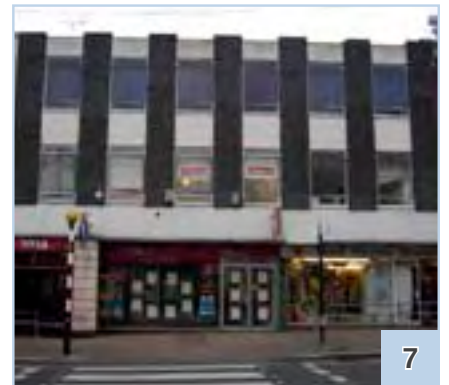


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# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



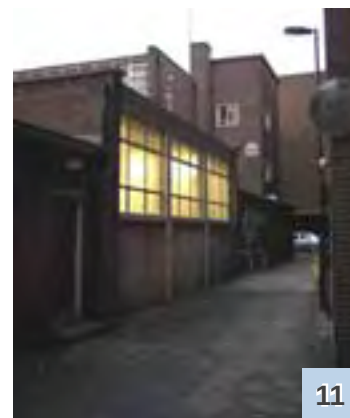
# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Buildings (continued)

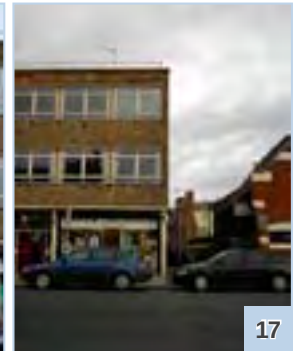
10. 28 to 30 High Street: Large expanses of blank facades fail to address the street and detract from the setting of the adjacent historic buildings.
11. Council Offices, Old Guildhall Yard: An anonymous building that fails to address the adjacent street, creating a dank, dark and uninviting courtyard to the rear.
12. Telephone Exchange, Priory Place: An anonymous building that breaks the historic line of buildings along Priory Place.
13. Post Office Extension, Priory Place: Stylistically at odds with the historic context, failing to respond to the Victorian building that it appends and rebuffing the adjacent street through the use of mirrored windows.
14. 24-26 Scot Lane: The elongated facade is at odds with the closer-grained, smaller historic buildings adjacent.
15. Consort House, Waterdale: Out of place in terms of scale, massing and style.
16. 8 Wood Street: as (17) below.
17. Cusworths Motorcycles to 33 Wood Street: Buildings devoid of any architectural flair or ambition that detract from the historic examples to the west end of Wood Street.
18. Crossgate House, Wood Street: Completely out of scale with the surrounding buildings.





# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis





# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Church Way

The creation of Church Way in the early 1970s had a disastrous impact on the Doncaster's historic centre, cutting a swathe through the densely packed streets and buildings on the western edge of the High Street Conservation Area and truncating the historic routes of French Gate and St George Gate, as well as separating St George's Minster from the main part of the town. The need to cross a busy road several carriageways wide compromises the access from the western side, and has a negative impact on the character of the area with the associated noise and utilitarian street furniture.

The road created a gap in the urban fabric. There is no building frontage; instead it is met with a service yard and the rear elevations of the large department stores on Baxter Gate, monolithic brick structures that effectively turn their back on the road. The only building that does address the street is a utilitarian modern office block, and even this presents an end elevation rather than fronting onto the pavement. It also creates further negative space in the guise of Old Guildhall Yard, a series of dark, dank alleyways that lead back onto French Gate.

The streetscape is completed by the flank wall of the public house that fronts onto French Gate, which was never intended to function as a primary elevations, having been built as part of a terrace. The overall effect is incoherent and uninviting.

It is recommended that the areas adjacent to Church Way be redeveloped and a new building frontage created. This would address the street, mask the rear of the Baxter Gate buildings and complete the urban block. Increased pedestrianisation together with traffic calming measures and the removal of the utilitarian street furniture will return some of the historic character of the area and reinstate the relationship between the town centre and St George's Minster.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



1901-06 Ordnance Survey map and 2007 version showing the creation of Church Way and the resultant loss of historic streets and buildings



The creation of Church Way exposed utilitarian and characterless rear elevations of the buildings fronting onto Baxter Gate with service yards to the front.



Spaces adjacent to Church Way present an untidy, incoherent appearance.



The utilitarian office block fails to address the street with a largely blank elevation (left) and creates a network of dark, uninviting alleys (old Guildhall yard, right).

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Areas and Spaces

There are a number of areas and spaces that have a negative impact on the High Street Conservation Area:

#### Printing Office Street

On the north side of Printing Office Street towards the western end there is a break in the otherwise continuous building frontage that leads to a service yard. The origins of this are historic; it appears on the 1852 Ordnance Survey map and is overlooked by the properties to the western side of Priory Place, but appears to have become a forgotten space characterised by its untidy appearance and utilitarian buildings and fixtures. There is a haphazard array of surfaces ranging from concrete to tarmac, walls formed by what appear to be extant sections of former buildings, steel palisade fencing, scrappy self-seeded vegetation, semi-full skips and bins, and a haphazard arrangement of parking spaces.

Whilst it is appreciated that such 'back of house' spaces are difficult to deal with and are of a lower priority than other more prominent examples, in the interest of enhancing the conservation area as a whole it is recommended that this and other similar areas are addressed. Some form of barrier that continues the building frontage, or restricts views into the area, or simply makes more of an announcement to the street may be appropriate rather than the gap that exists currently. Inside the space the use of more sympathetic surfaces such as natural stone cobbles, simple landscaping and planting and rationalisation of the parking arrangement would improve the overall appearance.

#### Printing Office Street / Cleveland Street

Another service yard, this is a modern intervention, created principally to service the new buildings to the north side of Printing Office Street and the eastern side of Priory Walk. Although generally in good order (the building elevations here are presentable, if uninspiring) the yard represents something of a gap in the urban fabric within this area. The 1852, 1901 & 1928 Ordnance Survey maps (see section 4.2.1, 19th & 20th centuries) all show a continuous building frontage at this point; consequently some form of screen or gateway that marks the building line whilst restricting views into the yard may be appropriate. Screening of the bins would also improve the situation.

There are also some interesting properties to the northern side of the entrance, one of which appears to be Georgian and retains an oval window. The origins of this structure should be explored further with a view to enhancing its profile within the area.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



1852 Ordnance Survey map showing service yard to north side of Printing Office Street



Service yard facing north



Service yard facing east; the rear of properties on Priory Place are in the background



Service yard facing west



Service yard to rear of properties on Cleveland Street / Printing Office Street.



Property with oval window to north side of service yard entrance

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Areas and Spaces (continued)

#### Priory Place (see also section 4.4.6 ; Green Spaces)

The space in front of the 1960s telephone exchange is currently under-used, featuring an electricity sub-station and separated from the street by utilitarian metal railings. It is recommended that the area be requisitioned as a public space, with the area landscaped and the line of planting represented by the lone cotoneaster specimen extended. This would screen the unattractive building behind and defining the line of the original street frontage.

#### Waterdale / Wood Street

The space to the corner of Waterdale and Wood Street is also under-exploited. Currently occupied by a public car park and the forecourts of the businesses that operate behind, located on a busy corner and overshadowed by the 6 storey Consort House, there is a sense that this is another forgotten area within the town fabric. It has never been built on (see historic Ordnance Survey maps, section 4.2.1, 19th & 20th centuries), and consequently should remain open, but the assets such as the church and mature tree specimen should be enhanced, forming the basis for future landscaping schemes. The space should also not be forgotten in the consideration of proposals for the former Girls' School site opposite.

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



Under-used space in front of |Priory Place Telephone Exchange



Under-exploited area to the junction of Waterdale and Wood Street



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.10 The Extent of Intrusion or Damage (Negative Factors)

#### Shopfronts & Shutters

The poor and unsympathetic design of many of the shop fronts and the use of security shutters has a negative effect on the historic character of the High Street Conservation Area. These often bear no relation to the appearance of the remainder of the façade in terms of structure and alignment (vertical elements seldom respond to the location of openings, etc, to upper floors), materials, colour, detail, scale and size of advertising lettering and logos. Large paned glazing is often at odds with the smaller paned approach to upper floors. The proliferation of security shutters also has serious implications on the appearance of buildings, their modern appearance compromises their historic qualities, both when open in terms of the additional depth of fascia required to house them when open, but most importantly when closed. This also provides a ready surface for graffiti and adds to the air of decline. Similarly, the use of 'Hong Kong' style banner signs to facades often has a deleterious effect on the buildings.

Detailed design guidance should be prepared so that owners are aware of what is required in terms of quality of design and materials, and effective enforcement of controls under Conservation Area legislation should be introduced, together with additional controls in the form of Article 4 directions to restrict practices allowed under permitted development but considered to be detrimental to the character of the Conservation Area.



Shutters, signage, altered shopfront and replacement window detracting from an historic facade on Hall Gate



Examples of poor shopfront (above) and sympathetic shopfront (below) on Priory Place



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### Hard Landscaping:

Within the High Street Conservation Area modern surfaces such as concrete paving slabs and pavements exist in a variety of colours and designs which distract from the historic buildings and compromise their setting. These are particularly prevalent to areas away from the more prestigious areas of town (where natural stone tends to be the material of choice) but which nonetheless contain a number of important historic buildings, such as Hall Gate.

Following historic investigation, consideration should be given to the re-introduction of materials that would reflect the historic character of the area, with an emphasis on the use of natural materials such as stone flags and granite cobbles.

### Street Furniture

This is often modern and utilitarian. Some progress has been made with the introduction of elements such as lamp posts and bollards that are more in-keeping with the historic character of the area, but there are still elements that appear superfluous and detract from the historic setting. Siting of street furniture also needs to be carefully considered to ensure that it does not impede movement on busy streets.



Hall Gate showing discordant mixture of surfaces together with utilitarian street furniture, detracting from the historic environment



Hall Gate surfaces

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.11 General Condition (of the Area and Built Fabric, Identification of Buildings at Risk)

Within the context of the town centre as a whole, High Street, St Sepulchre Gate, French Gate and Baxter Gate represent primary retail areas, occupied by larger retailers of sufficiently high profile to ensure that buildings are kept in good repair. However, alongside these (and even on High Street itself) there are a number of retailers at the other end of the spectrum, with small limited resources to spend on the upkeep of buildings.

The result of this is that whilst the condition of some buildings within the conservation area is generally good, others are suffering and are in need of attention. The lack of access to upper floors of properties also means that whilst ground storeys may be presentable and in use, those above are often in poor condition and either vacant or under-utilised.

This is then further compounded by a basic lack of awareness and understanding of the historic significance and character of the area, which results in poor treatment of the buildings in terms of materials and design for both repairs and alterations.

This could be addressed in a number of ways:

- Education via exhibitions, advertising, tours, etc, to enthuse and inform local people and buildings owners about the heritage of the area and the importance of safeguarding it for the future
- Grant schemes to encourage property owners to improve their properties.
- Education on how to carry out historically correct repairs and alterations
- Schemes to improve access to upper floors of properties, with particular reference to the Living Over the Shop scheme.

There are no entries for Doncaster town centre on English Heritage's Buildings at Risk Register, which covers listed buildings. Outside of this, whilst some buildings are in a poor state of repair, few currently fit into the category of being 'at risk'. However, nos. 13, 14 and 15 Hall Gate (each surviving examples of simple Georgian houses) are particularly vulnerable; buildings to the adjacent site have been demolished, and these remaining three could suffer the same fate unless immediate action is taken.



# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis



A gap in the historic street frontage of Hall Gate due to demolition



Buildings at risk on Hall Gate; nos. 13, 14 and 15



Buildings in a poor state of repair on Hall Gate



Buildings in a poor state of repair on High Street (left) and Cleveland Street (right)

# Assessing Special Interest

## 4.4 Character Analysis

### 4.4.12 Problems, Pressures and the Capacity for Change

Whilst some areas of the High Street Conservation Area appear to be thriving, in particular the area around the junction between French Gate, St Sepulchre Gate, High Street and Baxter Gate, with numerous national retailers and plenty of investment, there are others that appear to be in decline.

There are some generic issues that underlie the more obvious problems manifest within the urban fabric within these areas. These concern the effects of heavy traffic where it has been displaced by pedestrianisation, problems associated with access both for commercial operators and the general public, and a low economic base associated with their status as secondary retail areas.

This in turn leads on to more specific problems, particularly vacancy and the neglect and general lack of maintenance of the existing historic buildings, the gradual erosion of detail through replacement windows and roofing materials and the painting of facades, poor control over alterations such as shopfronts, inappropriate advertising and signage, and ill-considered surfacing and utilitarian street furniture further detracting from the character of the area.

Commercial properties within conservation areas have no permitted development rights, which means that permission must be obtained to replace elements such as windows, doors and shopfronts, as well as other similar alterations. However, additional controls in the form of Article 4(1) directions should be introduced to prevent further erosion of the area's special interest. These could be particularly effective with regard to the control of external painting of commercial properties. The erection of signage and advertisements, could be further controlled by the conservation area being considered as an area where there are special control over advertisements.

The potential capacity for beneficial change within the High Street Conservation Area is great. There are proposals for redevelopment along some of the most blighted areas along Church Way and the creation of a so-called 'cultural quarter' centring on the former Girls' School on Waterdale, so the impetus for change and enhancement already exists; it is simply a case of putting this into action. Public consultations (see section 5.1) have also revealed an enthusiasm amongst the public at large for the preservation and enhancement of the historic character of the town. The historical development of the High Street Conservation Area reveals it to be a dynamic and evolving place that has been subject to many influences, and it needs to continue to do this into the future. However, this should not happen at the expense of the historic fabric of the town, as has happened during some episodes of its more recent past. To ensure that its unique characteristics are preserved and carried through into any new development it needs to pay careful attention to historic patterns of development, scale and massing of buildings, plot sizes, building styles and key views and vistas.



## ANTICIPATED CHANGES WITHIN DONCASTER TOWN CENTRE



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- |                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  Proposed re-configuring to make new square, Realignment and narrowing of Church Way |  New educational city area                                         |
|  Proposed development                                                                |  Proposed waterfront park                                          |
|  Major refurbishment of Wool Market (Elden Minns & Co.)                              |  New cultural quarter                                              |
|  Application for a new hotel in High Fisher Gate                                     |  Improved connections and crossing to St. George                   |
|  Creation of new buildings that front onto to Church Way                             |  Proposed access to Educational City with connection to new marina |
|  Application has been made to demolish 10-14 Hall Gate and build public house        |  Links to new waterfront park                                      |
|                                                                                                                                                                         |  Improved connections and crossing to the railway station          |
|                                                                                                                                                                         |  Major area of improvements                                        |





the bluebuilding



SPORTS





# Community Involvement

# 5

## Introduction

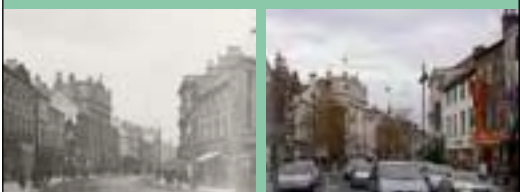
In line with Doncaster Council's Statement of Community Involvement a programme of consultation was drawn up with the aim of getting local people's views about both the conservation appraisal and the management plan. It was decided that instead of running two separate consultations, one for the Market Place and one for the High Street, the consultations for the two areas should be combined as many of the consultees would have an interest in both areas.

At the commencement of the project a database was created with the contact details of key stakeholders including residents' associations, the police and community safety officers, local businesses and traders associations, local councillors, key Council officials, organisations with an interest in heritage and conservation and around 400 freehold properties in the conservation areas.

## The First Exhibition

The first stage of the consultation was an exhibition held on Saturday 27 January. The purpose of the exhibition was to find out what local people value about the conservation areas for example the character of the areas or the buildings they like and dislike most and why.

Letters were sent to everyone on the database in early January and more than 1,000 flyers were distributed with information about the process and the purpose of the project. The flyers were distributed by members of the JTP Community Planning team who explained the process and encouraged recipients to attend the Exhibition. The Market Manager circulated flyers to Market traders. An advertisement was placed in the local free paper in the week leading up to the first Exhibition.

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|    <h3 style="text-align: center;">INVITATION</h3> <p>You are invited to a public consultation event to find out more about the historic character of the town centre and market place and to have your say on the conservation and regeneration of your town centre.</p> <p style="text-align: center;"><b>Saturday 27 January 10am - 3pm</b><br/> <b>The Corn Exchange, Doncaster</b></p> <p>Alternatively, simply come and view the information at<br/>         The Design Centre, The Blue Building, Doncaster High Street<br/>         between Monday 29 January and Saturday 3 February 10am - 4pm</p> <p style="text-align: center;"><b>Everyone is Welcome</b></p> <p style="font-size: small;">For more information please contact Nicola Forde, Community Planner,<br/>         John Thompson and Partners, 43 Hatton Garden, London EC1N 8EL. Tel: 020 7405 1211 Email: n.f@jtp.co.uk<br/> <a href="http://www.communityplanning.co.uk">www.communityplanning.co.uk</a></p>  | <h3 style="text-align: center;">DONCASTER PUBLIC CONSULTATION<br/>MARKET PLACE &amp; HIGH STREET CONSERVATION AREAS</h3> <h4 style="text-align: center;">QUESTIONNAIRE &amp; COMMENTS SHEET</h4> <p>Please look through the Exhibition and let us know what you think by completing this form and handing it back to us or returning it to the contact below by Friday 2 February 2007.<br/>         Nicola Forde, John Thompson &amp; Partners, Wren House, 43 Hatton Garden, London, EC1N 8EL.</p> <p>Do you have any comments or additions you would make to the character assessment?<br/>         Please tell us what you like most about the area.</p> <p>Do you believe there should be more control the Conservation Areas? For example:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• possible extensions of the Conservation Areas</li> <li>• more protection e.g. features doors or window design?</li> </ul> <p>Do you have any views on possible new developments that may affect the character of the Conservation Areas, for example in Church Way or Market Place?</p> <p>Any other comments?<br/>         Please mark up the map overleaf with your ideas</p> <p><b>Would you be interested in further consultations?</b></p> <p><input type="checkbox"/> Yes <input type="checkbox"/> No</p> <p>If yes please ensure you fill in your contact details below</p> <p><b>Name</b> .....</p> <p><b>Address</b> .....</p> <p>.....</p> <p>.....</p> <p>.....</p> |
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# Community Involvement

The exhibition was held on the mezzanine of the Corn Exchange between 10am and 4pm on Saturday 27 January and on a market stall outside the Blue Building on the High Street. This was a good way of raising the profile of the project with shoppers who visit the conservation area and use the facilities but do not live there.

The Exhibition consisted of fourteen panels. An accompanying questionnaire sought the public's comments. The panels were on display in the Blue Building in the High Street for the month following and on the website [www.communityplanning.co.uk](http://www.communityplanning.co.uk), a downloadable copy of the questionnaire was also available on the website and at the Blue Building.

More than 100 people viewed the exhibition with 47 filling in questionnaires. The following is summary of their responses:

## What people liked about the Conservation Areas

- age and character
- the random nature of the buildings
- the character of the outdoor markets
- the Market Place
- the variety of shops and market stalls
- Church Way
- Dixon's building on High Street
- the Mansion House

*"I like the random nature of the buildings that somehow blend into a pleasing overall form. If only the shop fronts would blend in."*





# Community Involvement

People also specifically mentioned what they liked adjacent to the conservation areas:

*“Please remember that Doncaster is a market town”*

- the Grand Theatre
- Regent Square
- South Parade,
- St James’ Pool and Leisure Centre
- the Minster

## **People were asked whether they thought there should there be more control in the Conservation Areas, for example protection of features?**

Respondents were overwhelmingly in favour of greater protection within the conservation areas, details such as doors and windows at ground floor level returned to the ‘original design’.

*‘The modern shop fronts spoil nearly all the old, lovely buildings’.*

People also wanted to see:

- new buildings made to blend in - not stand out like a sore thumb
- rigid rules on the frontage of buildings especially at ground level as happens in many European historic towns
- greater enforcement of existing controls to ensure new build and alterations conform and fit in.
- buildings in poor repair properly maintained
- more control over shop fronts and signage in general.

*“We don’t need so much control as encouragement by the Council to help spruce up parts of the area”*

## **People were asked whether the Conservation Areas should be extended**

Many people felt that conservation areas should be extended – people didn’t want to see what remains of Doncaster’s heritage lost

*“The Conservation Areas should be extended as soon as possible before we lose some more real gems”*

*“Extend areas to encourage development not limit it”*

Doncaster Civic Trust responded fully to the questionnaire and agreed with the notable but unlisted buildings identified on the exhibition boards but suggested there are ‘others of equal importance’.

Only one respondent felt that Conservation Areas restricted development,

*“People should be able to do what they like”.*

# Community Involvement

## People were asked for their views on new developments that may affect the character of the Conservation Areas

Many people were happy to see change as long as it was in keeping with the existing character of the area and of high quality.

*“....Frenchgate - could be anywhere. The “College Hub” does not fit in.”*

People were positive about:

- the proposals for the Great Street (Church Way) scheme and the way the buildings would be designed to address the Minster. A feasibility study should be commissioned
- the replacement of St George’s Roundabout with a large T junction
- proposals to renovate the Wool Market *“Character is an overused word. The wool market has no character at all”*
- the proposal to change the Market Area into a city square

*“I believe this (scheme) to be of fundamental significance and will help to establish Doncaster as a city”.*

*“New buildings should be “striking” and “innovative” rather than corporate”*

*“I like the mix of buildings of different ages as now so please do not ban new designs in future, just be sure that they are quality built.”*

However proposals to put a hotel on High Fisher Gate were criticised;

*“It is overpoweringly high, out of keeping with the area and blocking a good view of Minster”*

## Ideas for improvements

### The Market

- worry about the viability of the market if parking is not improved and particularly need secure parking for stall holders, lower parking charges, more parking close to the market, longer parking times in the market car park.
- market stalls should be permanent not demountable
- cover for the stalls so the public don’t get wet
- smarter market stalls in keeping with the Corn Exchange.

### Streetscape

- pedestrianise the High Street and the Market Place.
- less street clutter
- repairing roads and pavements would help.

# Community Involvement

## Community life

- create a central meeting place in the market
- keep local people involved and informed about change.

## Improvements to particular areas

- Hall Gate is just pubs and bars, needs more shops
- shop fronts - Bradford Row, now covered
- open up Cleveland Street bus lane to all traffic
- create a safer and easier access to the river front
- close dual carriage way in front of the Minster and open up North Bridge to all traffic.

## Other Comments

*"No more pubs.. Give us back our town at night."*

- there are not enough hotels
- closure of the southern bus station affected High Street shops
- poor relationship between locals and the council/market management
- poor access from the station to the town
- the unattractive appearance of the French Gate Centre (the foil)

Following the Exhibition the JTP team analysed and summarised the feedback received into Key Themes which would inform the emerging proposals for management of the Conservation Areas.

## Key Themes

- retain the character of the Conservation Areas by ensuring no buildings or areas with character are lost to development
- maintain the buildings and streets and enforce regulations that protect character
- new development must be in keeping with the character of the area – it can be modern but not out of place, must be in scale and must add to what is already there such as the views
- when the chance comes renovate buildings to enhance their architectural character – e.g. shop fronts, doors and window detailing
- extend the conservation areas so that all buildings of character are protected
- remedy the divisions between the town centre, market place and riverside and Minster
- take measures to ensure the market survives; it is central to the character of Doncaster.





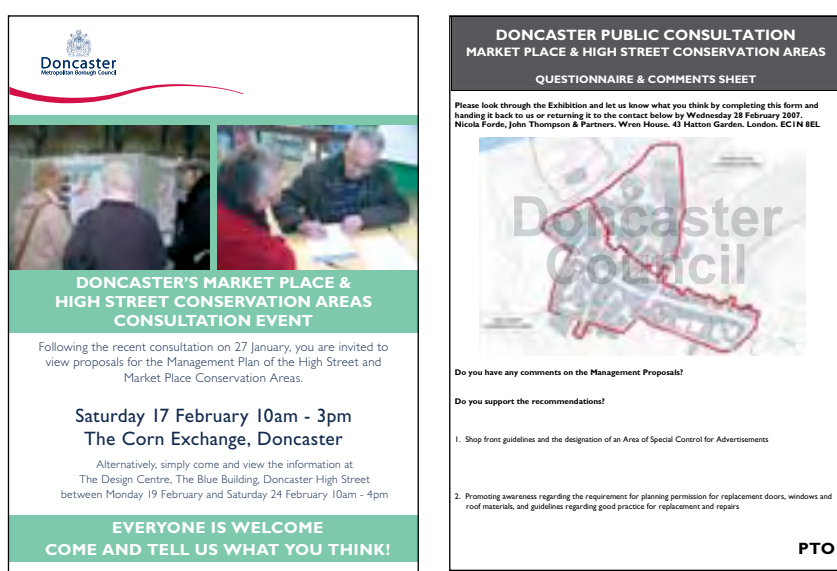
# Community Involvement

## The Second Exhibition

The second Exhibition took place on Saturday 17 February 2007. People who had attended the first Exhibition and returned questionnaires were added to the database and the whole database was sent an invitation letter. A flyer was produced and again more than 1,000 were distributed by members of the JTP team. Some time was taken to distribute flyers to the Market stalls and to encourage them to attend the Exhibition. An advertisement was placed in the local newspaper.

As before the Exhibition was held on the mezzanine inside the Corn Exchange and a stall placed outside the Blue Building on the High Street between 10am and 4pm on 17 February, the Exhibition was on display inside the Design Centre at the Blue Building in the weeks that followed and available on the website: [www.communityplanning.co.uk](http://www.communityplanning.co.uk).

The purpose of the second exhibition was to get people's views on the management proposals and a questionnaire was prepared so that people could give feedback on specific points.



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## Questionnaire responses

Again there was a good turn out to the Exhibition, however as many people had already filled in a questionnaire from the first Exhibition only 18 questionnaires were returned this time. People were generally very positive about the proposals and felt that the comments from the first Exhibition had been listened to. One respondent felt that more consultation was needed and one respondent felt recommendations could go further - *"What is the long-term strategy here? 10 years? 15/20 years?"*

**People were asked what they thought about the recommendations for shop front guidelines and the designation of an Area of Special Control for Advertisements.**

Most people agreed with the recommendations

*"Yes. This is an excellent proposal. Remove the tackiness of the area which currently has cheap plastic shop fronts."*

# Community Involvement

Specific points made:

- grants/encouragement to speed up the changes rather than waiting decades for shops to change hands or refurbishments.
- use sustainable materials for things like windows and gutters (not plastic).

## **People were asked what they thought about recommendations to promote awareness of regulations within Conservation Areas**

People agreed to proposals to promote awareness regarding the requirement for planning permission for replacement doors, windows and roof materials, and guidelines regarding good practice for replacement and repairs.

*“This is essential. Many people do not know they are in a conservation area or where they should go for information”.*

Specific points made:

- not just promotion but regulation
- there needs to be some flexibility and justification or business case if businesses need to break the rules
- do not discourage real investment based on these rules.

## **People were asked what they thought about recommendations to further control alterations that affect the character and appearance of the Conservation Areas**

This recommendation was broadly supported, however one respondent felt that more information was needed “the public see the law as boring and complicated and don’t realise its importance”.

### **People were asked what they thought about:**

- Making the northern market into an open area with demountable stalls

*“Not sure about this. I think we need a traditional look”*

Opinions were split on this half felt it was a good ideal, half were unsure, specific points were:

- retain the old fish market and a traditional look
- it would be good if the space can be used on non-market days
- erect a statue to commemorate an eminent Doncastrian
- provide parking (traders), improve access and public transport links, public toilets, have stalls with working behind in vehicles

# Community Involvement

- De-cluttering the streets The majority of respondents agreed with the ideas, specific points were:
  - several signs could be put together on one signpost
  - de-clutter “yes” but add objects that add value and character to the area e.g. fountains, statues, seating
- Improving Hall Gate. Respondents agreed with proposals to improve Hall Gate
  - the proposal to put a bus stop outside A&G narrows the road too much, should the whole road be narrowed?
  - grant permission for the pub - it’s a gaping eyesore
  - tidy up the burnt out shop on Hall Gate.
- Use of High Quality Natural Materials. People agreed with this recommendation.

## People were asked what they thought about the proposed guidelines for new development:

- Protecting views

Opinions on this varied, whilst the majority of people agreed the following points were made:

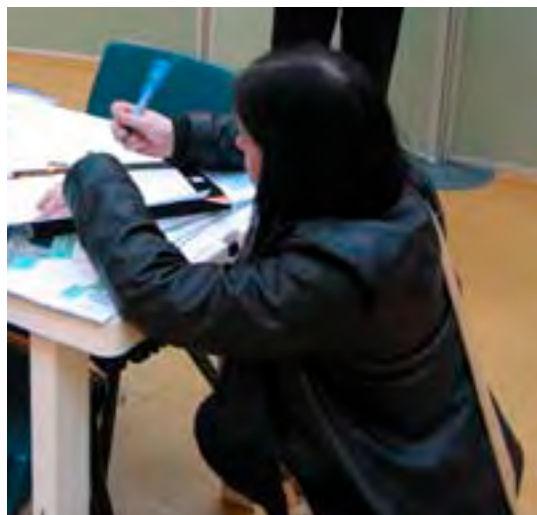
*“This idea is a must not just for locals but also for tourists”*

*“Yes essential - a characteristic of Doncaster is no high rise”*

*“this is dependant on the type of building that may block the view i.e. if a developer wanted to build high-rise apartments in the Cultural Quarter then maybe they should. Name the area e.g. Cultural Quarter, Market Quarter, Medieval Quarter”.*

Other ideas were:

- designate which streets / areas should be kept traditional in design and which should be modern
- an information board in the market informing people about the history - people will appreciate the area if they are more informed.





# Community Involvement

## People were asked what they thought about possible extensions of the Conservation Areas

Most people agreed with the proposed extensions, specific comments were:

- Waterdale:
  - even though is ugly it is still part of the town's history.
  - Frenchgate Centre drains everything (life/shoppers etc) from Waterdale. Something should be done to remedy this
  - the shop fronts of Waterdale (Road not precinct) add tremendously to the look of the area.
  - make sure there is transport so people can shop in Waterdale
  - Printing Office Street has some lovely buildings and good example of new redevelopment.
- St Sepulchre Gate:
  - put in a statue of Roman soldier
  - the area around the two streets behind/following the Halifax building are not good ones, maybe they should not be included?

## People were asked if they had any other comments

*"No point preserving what we have if we don't make more effort on design of new build. It will cost more - BUT we are worth it!"*

*"This display was an excellent idea and made public aware of issues"*

*"What you've got you should look after the Mansion House is dirty and neglected".*

*"Actively encourage City Centre living, and apartments... breathe real life into the area."*

*"I think the management proposals are very good."*

## Summary

People were generally very positive about the proposals and felt that the comments from the first Exhibition had been listened to. One respondent felt that more consultation was needed.

People generally wanted to see the buildings and areas which add to Doncaster's heritage identified and protected before they were lost. They wanted stronger enforcement of Conservation Area regulations and the introduction of measures to protect and restore character such as shop front guidelines. People also felt it was essential that proposals support the economic vitality of the areas: shopping in the High Street and Waterdale and the market which is intrinsic to Doncaster's character. For example they wanted to see good transport links and measures taken to ease accessibility such as adequate parking provision.

People were not against modern development as long as it was in keeping and of high quality. They did not want development which did not add to what Doncaster already has by, for example blocking views, creating congestion or making parts of the city inaccessible. They supported ideas to make the river and the Minster more accessible.